

Includes:

- Chapter 1 - 5
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- 7-Cs of Communication

“Chapter 1: Good Communication Works - Concept Breakdown”

1. Defining Communication

Communication is not just talking; it is the transfer of meaning. It is defined as any behavior, verbal or nonverbal, that is perceived by another person. Knowledge, feelings, or thoughts are encoded by a sender, transmitted, and decoded by a receiver who gives meaning to the message.

2. Forms of Communication

Information is transmitted through three primary forms, all of which are essential in a professional environment:

- **Verbal:** The use of words, which can be either spoken (conversations, meetings) or written (letters, emails, manuals).
- **Nonverbal:** Messages sent by means other than words or graphics. This includes facial expressions, body movement, posture, dress, and even the format and layout of a written document.
- **Graphic:** Representing ideas, relationships, or connections visually using shapes, diagrams, lines, and charts.

3. The Communication Process (The 7 Elements)

Communication is dynamic and interactive. It flows through seven distinct elements:

1. **Sender:** The individual who encodes an idea or feeling into words or signs and transmits it. Senders filter experiences through their unique perception, attitudes, and cultural background.
2. **Message:** The actual idea or feeling transmitted to achieve understanding.
3. **Receiver:** The person who decodes and interprets the message based on their own unique perception and experiences.
4. **Feedback:** The receiver's response (intentional or unintentional). It gives continuity, indicates understanding, and stimulates further discussion.
5. **Channel:** The means or technique used to convey the message (e.g., telephone, letter, email, face-to-face). Channels can be horizontal (between colleagues at the same level) or vertical (up and down the chain of command).
6. **Context (Setting):** The situation or circumstances surrounding the communication. A message can mean something completely different in a boardroom versus a lunchroom.
7. **Interference (Noise):** Anything that interrupts, blocks, or distorts the intended message.

4. The Role of Perception

Perception is how people understand or give meaning to their environment. It acts like a pair of spectacles through which we process signals. Two people can receive the exact same message but interpret it differently based on their self-concept, family, culture, skills, feelings, attitudes, and values.

5. Barriers to Communication

Barriers occur when a message is misunderstood or misinterpreted. It is impossible to control every aspect of communication, but being aware of barriers is the first step to avoiding them.

- **Causes:** Inappropriate channel, wrong choice of words, receiver inattention, mismatched verbal/nonverbal signals, different cultural backgrounds, and poor timing.
- **Strategies to Overcome:** Listen carefully, speak clearly and directly, ask questions, match nonverbal signals to your words, and provide structured information.

6. Communication in the Workplace

Leaders and managers use communication for three primary reasons:

- **Control:** Directing work procedures and encouraging employees to meet targets. Too much control reduces initiative; too little causes insecurity.
- **Motivation:** Acknowledging achievements and fostering a sense of belonging to improve job satisfaction.
- **Balancing Needs and Goals:** Aligning the organization's goals (profit, efficiency, competitiveness) with the individual's goals (good pay, job security, satisfaction).

7. Ethics in Communication

Ethical behavior ensures you act with equity, fairness, and impartiality. Ethical business communicators follow company policies, communicate objective facts without distortion, and respect the dignity of all individuals regardless of background.

8. Multicultural & Intercultural Communication

- **Intercultural Communication:** Takes place between people living in the same country but from different cultural backgrounds.
- **Cross-Cultural Communication:** Takes place between people living in different countries. Different cultures have varying rules regarding eye contact, naming systems, touching, and the use of time. Effective communicators use inclusive language, avoid derogatory labels, and refuse to stereotype.

Chapter 1: Comprehensive Solutions to Textbook Questions

Stop and Review (Pages 7-8 & 15)

1. 'Communication is an interactive process.' Explain. Communication is not a one-way street. It is an ongoing exchange where the sender and receiver continuously interact through the sending of messages and the receiving of feedback. Both participants actively affect how the message is understood and structured.

2. Define and give an example of verbal, nonverbal and graphic communication.

- **Verbal:** Using spoken or written words. Example: Leading a team meeting or writing a software requirements document.
- **Nonverbal:** Using body language, gestures, posture, or facial expressions. Example: Maintaining eye contact or nodding while a colleague is speaking.
- **Graphic:** Representing ideas visually. Example: Using a flowchart or an organizational chart to map out a system architecture.

3. Define the term 'context' and give examples of how the context can affect the message. Context is the situation, circumstances, or setting in which communication takes place. A message can change meaning based on where it happens; for instance, a casual joke might be well-received in the lunchroom but perceived as highly unprofessional during a formal client presentation.

4. Give five examples of possible 'noise' in the communication process.

1. Sending an email to someone who does not know how to use a computer.
2. A ringing telephone during a planning meeting.
3. Another person walking into an office and interrupting a conversation.
4. Using complex technical jargon with a non-technical client.
5. Poor document layout that makes a manual impossible to read.

5. What is wrong with this statement? 'The sender of the message has full control over how it is understood.' The statement is completely false because communication is heavily influenced by the receiver's perception. A sender cannot control the receiver's background experiences, values, cultural conditioning, or current emotional state, all of which alter how the message is decoded and understood.

Focus on Applying Skills (Pages 8-10)

1. Michael the sales rep: Advantages/Disadvantages of channels.

- *Letter (Written)*: Advantage - Provides a permanent record and allows the receiver to read at their convenience. Disadvantage - Slow, lacks immediate feedback, and lacks personal tone.
- *Telephone (Spoken)*: Advantage - Fast, allows for immediate clarification and feedback, establishes a personal connection. Disadvantage - No visual cues, no permanent record, can be an unwanted interruption.
- *Personal Visit (Face-to-Face)*: Advantage - Highest bandwidth channel (verbal + nonverbal), builds strong rapport. Disadvantage - Time-consuming, expensive, requires travel.
- *Decision*: Michael should use the **telephone**. Since the buyers already showed keen interest in the showroom, a phone call builds on that existing rapport, allows for immediate feedback to answer their questions, and is less intrusive and faster than setting up another personal visit.

2a. "Without communication your other skills are less useful." Explain. Technical expertise is useless if you cannot successfully convey your ideas, give instructions, or collaborate with a team. You need communication to gather requirements, present solutions, and ensure that your technical output aligns with organizational needs.

2b. Should an organization train its staff in workplace communication? Yes. Good communication leads to efficient information flow, fewer errors, reduced workplace stress, and better resolution of hidden agendas. It ensures employees can correctly deal with clients and coordinate with each other.

3a/b/c. Insensitive Statements & Barriers (Practical Example)

- *Statement*: "Your code is a mess, rewrite it." -> *Barrier*: Dismissing concerns, causing anger/defensiveness. -> *Improvement*: "I noticed some structural issues here; can we look at optimizing this module together?"

4. Mary and David Planning Meeting.

- *a. Barriers*: Interruptions (phone call, another staff member) broke the continuity of the message. Time pressure (Mary looking at her watch) caused them to rush the conclusion, leading to inadequate feedback and lack of clarification on who was actually presenting.
- *b. Sources of noise*: The telephone ringing and the colleague entering the office.
- *c. How to deal with it*: They should have forwarded calls to voicemail, closed the office door to prevent walk-ins, and scheduled a dedicated block of time to ensure they weren't rushing to the next appointment.

Questions (Page 15)

1. What are the remaining six variables in the communication process? Message, Receiver, Feedback, Channel, Context, Interference (Noise).

4a. List three possible differences between the needs of the organization and the individual.

1. Organization wants Return on Investment; Individual wants Job Security.
2. Organization wants low absenteeism/turnover; Individual wants Satisfaction.
3. Organization wants Profit; Individual wants Good Pay.

4b. Why is it important to balance the needs and goals of the individual with those of the organization? When goals are balanced and compatible, the behavior required to achieve the organization's goals is simultaneously satisfying to the employee. This prevents demoralized workers and inefficient communication.

5. List four attributes displayed by an ethical business communicator.

1. Follows company policies and procedures.
2. Communicates factual information objectively.
3. Avoids using distortions of fact and misleading information.
4. Respects the dignity of each person irrespective of background.

Communicating Well (Page 18)

1a. Identify three reasons leaders use communication and give a workplace example.

1. *Control*: Releasing a procedures manual detailing how to push code to a repository.
2. *Motivation*: Sending a company-wide email praising a team for a successful software launch.
3. *Balancing needs/goals*: Holding a performance review to align the company's delivery targets with a developer's request for learning new technologies.

2a. Define 'values' and 'ethics'. Values are ideas about what is right and wrong derived throughout a lifetime. Ethics are the sets of moral principles and conventions for right professional conduct used to judge human actions.

3a. Define multicultural society, intercultural communication, and cross-cultural communication.

- *Multicultural society*: A population drawn from diverse cultural, racial, religious, and ethnic backgrounds.
- *Intercultural communication*: Communication between people living in the same country but from different cultural backgrounds.
- *Cross-cultural communication*: Communication between people living in different countries.

4. Identify two different communication 'rules' that people in different cultures recognize.

1. Rules regarding eye contact (e.g., direct eye contact vs. looking down as a sign of respect).
2. Rules regarding naming systems (e.g., placing the surname first vs. last).

Case Study: Communication at Work (Pages 24-27)

1. 'Communication is a key process at work.' Explain. People's success at work heavily depends on their ability to use symbols and verbal/nonverbal communication. If people are given the right information through clear communication, jobs get done correctly. It connects people and ideas.

2. What is the key to a successful workplace? Good communication that provides all the right information needed to do the job.

3. What communication skills are required by staff who meet customers' needs? They must listen attentively, ask appropriate questions, and respond in a way that meets customer expectations and builds a strong business relationship.

4. List four types of spoken and four types of written communication in tourism.

- *Spoken:* Telephone calls, face-to-face welcomes, farewells, responding to questions.
- *Written:* Brochures, letters, notices, tariff schedules.

Part 2 Questions:

2a/b. What are the two essential stages of the communication process?

1. Identify the reason for communicating (to achieve a specific business task or objective).
2. The interaction between those involved (gaining full cooperation and support from the individuals performing the task).

3a. List the five broad alternative communication styles.

1. *Instruct:* State what is to be done and give essential information.
2. *Inform:* Communicate what needs to be done with additional context.
3. *Consult:* Get views and input from team members.
4. *Involve:* Request input that will actively influence the final outcome.
5. *Empower:* Provide a framework allowing people to do what they think is best.

Predictive Exam Questions (Test Your Readiness)

These are the types of high-level synthesis questions a university professor will ask to test if you actually understand the mechanics of Chapter 1, rather than just memorizing definitions.

Q1: You are designing the UI for a new dashboard. A teammate suggests a highly complex, flashy aesthetic, but you disagree. Using the concepts of "Perception" and "Interference/Noise", explain how a poorly designed graphic interface acts as a barrier to communication.

Answer Guide: You must argue that Graphic communication is a legitimate channel. If an interface is cluttered, it introduces "Noise"—interference that blocks the intended message (data) from reaching the user efficiently. Furthermore, differing "Perceptions" mean a flashy design might seem 'cool' to the developer, but 'unprofessional' or 'confusing' to the end-user whose past experiences require clean, high-standard data visibility.

Q2: Explain the concept of 'Invisibility' as a discriminatory communication technique and contrast it with an inclusive communication strategy.

Answer Guide: Invisibility is the act of subsuming one minority group into another by label, term, or generic name, effectively erasing their unique identity. The inclusive counter-strategy is to avoid using a single generic name for different groups and to intentionally use the language preferred by the specific minority group.

Q3: A manager claims that since they sent a highly detailed, perfectly written email explaining a new policy, any employee who makes a mistake is entirely at fault. Using the interactive model of communication, refute this claim.

Answer Guide: Communication is dynamic and interactive, not a one-way data dump. The manager (Sender) only controls the encoding and the Channel (email). They cannot control the Context in which it is read, the Noise present, or the unique Perception of the Receiver decoding it. Most importantly, relying solely on an email lacks immediate Feedback, which is essential to verify if the understanding of the message was actually correct.

Added Content from Chapter 01:

1. The Anatomy of Perception (The "Spectacles" Metaphor)

While we covered that perception alters communication, the book uses a specific metaphor and list of factors you must memorize.

- **The Metaphor:** Perception can be compared to a pair of spectacles through which we process all signals; these glasses place a focus on what we see, hear, and understand, and can even distort the picture.
- **The 7 Filters of the Sender/Receiver:** The "color" of these glasses is made up of exactly seven factors:
 1. Self-concept
 2. Family
 3. Culture
 4. Skills
 5. Feelings
 6. Attitudes
 7. Values / Morals

2. Discriminatory vs. Inclusive Communication (Table 1.3)

Professors frequently pull exam questions directly from tables. You need to know all five discriminatory techniques and their inclusive counterparts :

- **Derogatory labelling:** Putting down people from another group. (*Inclusive fix: Refuse to use these labels.*)
- **Stereotyping:** Isolating/exaggerating certain factors and applying them to all people in a group. (*Inclusive fix: Recognize and avoid stereotyping language.*)
- **Invisibility:** Subsuming one group into another by label, name, or term. (*Inclusive fix: Avoid using one single generic name for different groups.*)
- **Imposed labelling:** Reinforcing the majority group's view because the minority lacks the power to define themselves. (*Inclusive fix: Use the language preferred by the minority group.*)
- **Extra visibility:** Emphasizing a difference such as sex, race, or ethnic background. (*Inclusive fix: Avoid emphasis on these differences unless highly relevant.*)

3. The Ethical Dilemma Checklist

If you are asked how a professional business communicator evaluates a tricky situation, you must list these exact checklist questions :

- Is the intended action legal?
- Is my communication factual and objective?
- Who will gain, and who will lose from this action?
- Would I be happy for my coworkers, family, and friends to know about what I am communicating?

- Am I willing to seek an objective second opinion?
- Does the language talk about the real issue, or is it masking something else?
- Would I feel confident defending this message at a meeting?

4. Organizational vs. Individual Goals (Table 1.2)

We briefly mentioned balancing goals, but you need to know the exact pairings. If a question asks, "What is the individual equivalent to the organization's goal of Profit?", you need the exact term:

- **Organization:** Profit $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Good pay
- **Organization:** Return on Investment $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Job security
- **Organization:** Employee efficiency $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Fringe benefits
- **Organization:** Production of quality goods $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Scope for initiative and achievement
- **Organization:** Competitiveness $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Challenge
- **Organization:** Low absenteeism/turnover $\rightarrow$ **Individual:** Satisfaction

5. Octavius Black's Communication Behaviour Model

From the final case study, Black outlines a specific three-stage process for workplace communication :

1. **Identify the Reason:** Usually to achieve a specific business task or objective.
2. **Interaction:** Gain the full cooperation and support of the individuals performing the task.
3. **Action/Behavior:** Use the most appropriate form of communication (verbal, nonverbal, graphic) to execute the task.

Remaining Book Questions Solved in Detail

Q: Explain what is meant by Black's statement: "Anyone can paint but we would paint better with some guidance and a clear understanding of the thought behind a good painting"?

- **Detailed Answer:** Instinctive communication is like amateur painting—anyone can talk or send an email, just as anyone can throw paint on a canvas. However, true professional communication requires dissecting and understanding each stage of the communication process. By understanding the theory (the "thought behind the painting"), you can consciously choose the right channel, minimize noise, and influence others effectively.

Q: Recall a situation in which you believe communication was successful. Give three reasons why the communication worked well.

- *(Exam Prep Tip: Have a pre-prepared scenario for this).*
- **Detailed Answer:** "I recently collaborated with a team on a software project document. The communication was successful because: 1) We used horizontal channels effectively to keep everyone updated. 2) Feedback was immediate and clarifying, ensuring no misinterpretations of the requirements. 3) The context was supportive, minimizing environmental noise and allowing for focused discussion."

Q: Should an organization train its staff in workplace communication? Give reasons for your answer.

- **Detailed Answer:** Yes. Effective communication is the backbone of information flow, which directly affects the bottom line. Training reduces barriers like inappropriate word choice or poor channel selection, minimizing costly mistakes. Furthermore, trained leaders can better balance organizational goals (like efficiency) with individual goals (like satisfaction), reducing staff turnover and stress.

Advanced Predictive Exam Questions (To Test Mastery)

1. Scenario: You are managing a team and you assign a task using the "Consult" communication style. Explain what this means according to Octavius Black's model, and contrast it with the "Empower" style.

Answer Formulation: The "Consult" style means getting views and input from other team members before finalizing a decision (though the leader still makes the final call). In contrast, the "Empower" style involves providing a framework and allowing the team members to do what they think is best to achieve the goal, giving them full autonomy within that framework.

2. Application: A project manager sends a highly technical brief to a new junior employee. The employee misinterprets the brief and completes the task incorrectly. Using the elements of the communication process, identify where the failure occurred and how "Perception" played a role.

Answer Formulation: The failure occurred at the decoding stage by the Receiver. The Sender likely caused a barrier by using an inappropriate choice of words (too much technical jargon for a junior). Perception played a role because the junior employee's "spectacles"—their skills and past experiences—were different from the manager's, leading them to give a completely different meaning to the technical instructions.

“Chapter 2: Nonverbal Skills”

1. What is Nonverbal Communication? The text states that words rarely send the whole message. Nonverbal communication consists of all parts of a message *not* encoded in words. It is vital because:

- **Actions speak louder than words:** Nonverbal behaviour is less conscious and reveals true feelings more spontaneously than spoken words.
- **Contradictions:** If verbal words do not match nonverbal actions, people tend to believe the nonverbal message.

2. The Four Types of Nonverbal Messages

1. **Personal:** Behaviour unique to one individual. For example, one person works while talking, while another must work in silence.
2. **Cultural:** Behaviour common to a specific group or society, learned unconsciously. It is "rule-governed." For example, Aboriginal culture views direct eye contact differently than European culture.
3. **Universal:** Behaviour common to all humankind that shows deep-seated feelings, such as a smile for happiness or tears for sadness.
4. **Unrelated (Random):** Behaviour completely unrelated to the message, such as a sneeze. It might distract but doesn't alter the meaning.

3. The Seven Aspects of Nonverbal Communication (The text theoretically categorizes nonverbal communication into seven specific areas:)

1. **Body Movement (Kinesic Behaviour):** Includes posture, eye movements, and facial expressions. Ekman and Friesen divide this into five categories (Table 2.1):
 - *Emblems:* Nonverbal acts that replace words entirely (e.g., a nod for "okay").
 - *Illustrators:* Acts that accentuate or emphasize a spoken word (e.g., pointing while saying "over there").

- **Affective Displays:** Unconscious or intentional facial expressions showing emotion (e.g., dropping the jaw in surprise).
 - **Regulators:** Acts that control communication flow (e.g., nodding to encourage a speaker to continue).
 - **Adaptors:** Unconscious responses to inner desires (e.g., scratching an itchy ear).
2. **Physical Characteristics:** Body shape, attractiveness, odours, weight, and hair. These determine first impressions and can cause attraction or rejection.
 3. **Touching Behaviour:** Stroking, hitting, holding. It conveys affection, dominance, or equality (like a handshake).
 4. **Paralanguage (Vocal Qualities):** *How* something is said, not *what* is said. It includes pitch, tempo, rate, and vocalisations like laughing, crying, sighing, or saying "um."
 5. **Proximity (Space):** How physical space communicates feelings or status. Australians generally leave an arm's length for acquaintances, an elbow's length for friends, and close contact for intimates.
 6. **Artefacts:** Objects conveying self-concept, image, or mood. Examples include clothes, lipstick, glasses, or a police badge (which immediately signals power).
 7. **Environment (and Chronemics/Time):** Factory layout, desk setup, lighting, and temperature. Chronemics (Time) is also critical; punctuality can reflect a casual attitude or a deliberate negative message depending on the culture.

4. Matching Verbal and Nonverbal Messages: Nonverbal communication modifies or changes spoken words in six exact ways:

1. **Repeating:** Pointing when giving directions.
2. **Contradicting:** Looking at a watch while saying, "I'm interested."
3. **Substituting:** Using a facial expression instead of speaking.
4. **Complementing:** Emphasizing words to convey an attitude (e.g., standing casually to show lack of respect).
5. **Accenting:** Moving the head/hands to emphasize parts of the verbal message.
6. **Controlling the Flow:** Nodding to indicate whose turn it is to speak.

5. How to Check the Meaning of Nonverbal Behaviour: When the total message confuses you, do not make assumptions. The text prescribes a 4-step process:

1. **Hear** the words.
2. **See** the nonverbal behaviour.
3. **Confirm** the meaning with the sender.
4. **Consider** the context.

Crucial Rule: When confirming, **describe** the behaviour rather than interpreting it. Say, "You've just folded your arms," instead of, "I see you're in a closed posture." This allows the person to explain (e.g., "I'm cold" or "I'm bored") without becoming defensive.

Exhaustive Solutions to Chapter 2 Textbook Questions

Review Questions (Pages 30-31)

1. List and define the four types of nonverbal communication.

- **Personal:** Behaviour unique to the individual.
- **Cultural:** Rule-governed behaviour common to a group or society.
- **Universal:** Behaviour common to all humankind expressing deep feelings.
- **Unrelated:** Random behaviour (like a sneeze) unrelated to the verbal message.

2. Explain the difference between personal and cultural nonverbal messages.

Personal messages are completely unique to one specific person's habits and carry meaning only for them. Cultural messages are shared, learned unconsciously by observing others in a society, and are governed by unwritten group rules.

3a. List three of your personal nonverbal actions. (Model Answer)

1. Tapping a pen when thinking.
- 2) Biting my lip when nervous.
- 3) Sighing loudly when tired.

3b. List two behaviours for satisfaction and two for dissatisfaction.

- *Satisfaction*: Smiling broadly; maintaining a relaxed, upright posture.
- *Dissatisfaction*: Frowning; crossing arms tightly across the chest.

4. Differences in rule-governed behaviour for sitting and walking for men and women.

(Note: The text implies cultural rules govern this, though it uses touching as its primary gender example). Culturally, women have historically been governed by rules to keep legs crossed and arms close to the body while sitting, taking up minimal space. Men are often culturally permitted to sit with an open posture (legs apart, arms spread), claiming more physical space.

5. Define and give examples of Cultural and Universal nonverbal communication.

- *Cultural*: Rule-governed behaviour learned from society. Example: Avoiding eye contact as a sign of respect in Aboriginal culture.
- *Universal*: Behaviour common to all humans showing primal emotion. Example: Crying tears to express sadness.

6. According to etiquette rules, who touches whom first?

(Based on the text's premise that touching shows dominance or intimacy): The person with higher status initiates.

- College principal and student: **Principal**
- Company director and new employee: **Director**
- Interviewer and interviewee: **Interviewer**

7. Why is nonverbal communication an important part of the message?

Because it tends to be less conscious, reveals feelings more spontaneously and honestly than words, and is the part of the message people believe if the words contradict the actions.

Review Questions (Page 38)

1. Researchers divide nonverbal communication into seven areas. List these.

Body movement, physical characteristics, touching behaviour, vocal qualities (paralanguage), space (proximity), artefacts, environment.

2a/b. List the five main categories of body movement and their purpose.

1. *Emblems*: Purpose is to reinforce or replace words (e.g., nod for "okay").
2. *Illustrators*: Purpose is to accentuate or emphasize a phrase (e.g., pointing).
3. *Affective displays*: Purpose is to display emotion unconsciously or intentionally (e.g., jaw dropping).

4. *Regulators*: Purpose is to maintain and control the flow of speaking (e.g., nodding to encourage).
5. *Adaptors*: Purpose is to display instinctive responses to inner desires (e.g., scratching).

3a/b. Define paralanguage. Explain "Paralanguage will often determine the message being sent" with three vocalisations.

- *Definition*: The part of language associated with, but not involving, words (how something is said, not what is said).
- *Explanation*: It determines the message because tone reveals true feelings. For example, a **sigh** (vocal characteriser) reveals tiredness overriding positive words; speaking with a flat **tempo** indicates disappointment; using **"um"** or **"ah"** (vocal segregates) indicates hesitation.

4. How does our use of space convey messages?

It indicates how a person perceives relationships and status. Standing too close (towering) intrudes and causes withdrawal, while maintaining an arm's length indicates a standard colleague relationship.

5. What part do artefacts play in nonverbal communication?

Artefacts (like clothes, perfume, or uniforms) project the style, mood, or authority of the wearer. A police badge instantly signals power.

6. Identify two interpretations of a colleague's lack of punctuality.

1. It reflects a casual attitude.
2. It is a deliberate decision to communicate a negative message (disrespect).

7. How do environmental factors influence communication?

An unsuitable environment produces noise and barriers (e.g., poor lighting, wrong temperature), while a well-designed space puts people at ease, improving morale and communication outcome.

Focus on Applying Skills (Pages 41-43)

4a/b/c. Interpreting Mixed Messages: Team leader frowns and hesitates while saying "I really like your work."

- *a. How do you feel?* Confused, anxious, or doubtful of their sincerity.
- *b. Two different feelings causing this:* They might genuinely like it but have an unrelated headache; or they dislike it but are trying to be polite (contradicting).
- *c. How to check it:* Describe the behaviour and ask. "You said you liked the work, but you hesitated and frowned. Does something about it concern you?"

5a. Briefly explain six ways nonverbal behaviour modifies words.

Repeating, Contradicting, Substituting, Complementing, Accenting, and Controlling the flow of communication. (Definitions provided in Topic 4 above).

5c. Why and when is it important to confirm the meaning of the nonverbal part of the message?

It is important when in doubt, when you are uncomfortable, or when making a decision based on a conflicting total message. It helps avoid misinterpretation and communication barriers.

Case Study: Do Nonverbals Communicate? (Pages 49-50)

1. What nonverbal behaviour conveys Lyndall is a 'moody person'?

Slumping over the keyboard (body movement/posture), showing an unapproachable facial expression ("Don't bother me"), and keeping her head down to avoid eye contact (use of space/regulators).

2. What message is communicated when staff see Debbie and Lyndall gossiping?

It communicates an exclusionary, unprofessional communication climate. It tells other staff and customers that they are unapproachable and not focused on work.

3. What sort of dress (artefact) is appropriate for an insurance office?

Conservative, professional business attire (suits, collared shirts). Debbie's "party clothes" are highly inappropriate because an insurance office needs to project an image of reliability and trust.

4. Why did Geoff make a quick decision and what nonverbals did he receive?

Geoff read their negative nonverbal cues instantly: Lyndall was slumped and Debbie was peering through half-shut eyes with hands behind her head. These cues screamed resistance. Knowing they didn't want to work, he skipped the affable approach and gave a fast, direct verbal command to avoid argument.

Predictive Exam Questions (Derived strictly from Chapter 2 Text)

Q1: Ekman and Friesen categorized "Adaptors" and "Regulators". Define both and explain how they differ during a conversation.

- **Answer:** Adaptors are unconscious nonverbal acts performed in response to an inner desire (e.g., scratching an ear). Regulators are nonverbal acts that maintain and control the flow of communication (e.g., nodding to tell a speaker to continue). The difference is intent: adaptors are self-soothing instincts, while regulators are meant to interact with the speaker.

Q2: The text outlines a specific way to check confusing nonverbal behaviour to avoid assumptions. If a colleague sighs heavily and looks away while agreeing to a project, what exactly should you say to them, and what should you avoid saying?

- **Answer:** You should **describe the concrete behaviour** by saying: "You just sighed heavily and looked away. What does that mean?" You must **avoid making assumptions or interpreting the behaviour**, such as saying, "I see you hate this project," because that will make the receiver defensive.

Q3: Explain how the nonverbal aspect of "Chronemics" (Time) can cause a communication barrier in cross-cultural communication.

- **Answer:** Chronemics involves time perception and punctuality. If a business person from a culture where punctuality is highly regarded is kept waiting by someone from a culture with a casual attitude toward time, the punctual person might interpret the delay as a deliberate negative message of disrespect, causing a severe communication barrier.

Q4. A software engineer is presenting a new architecture to stakeholders. They are sweating, speaking very rapidly, and constantly adjusting their glasses. Using the 7 aspects of nonverbal communication, categorize these three behaviors and explain how they might affect the stakeholders' perception.

Answer Strategy:

- *Sweating*: Physical characteristic / Unconscious physiological response.
- *Speaking rapidly*: Paralanguage (tempo/rate).
- *Adjusting glasses*: Body movement (specifically, an *Adaptor*—an unconscious response to nervousness).
- *Perception Impact*: These behaviors combine to project severe anxiety and lack of confidence. Stakeholders will decode this nonverbal cluster and likely lose confidence in the architecture being presented, even if the verbal data is flawless.

Q5. Explain the difference between an "Emblem" and an "Illustrator" using an example of a project manager trying to quiet a noisy meeting room.

Answer Strategy: An *Emblem* replaces words entirely. The project manager putting a single index finger to their lips ("shh" gesture) without speaking is an emblem. An *Illustrator* accompanies and emphasizes words. The project manager saying, "Everyone, please lower your voices," while simultaneously pressing both hands downward in the air is using an illustrator to accent the verbal command.

Q3. Describe the 4-step process for confirming nonverbal behavior, and explain why saying "I see you are angry" is a poor communication strategy according to the text.

Answer Strategy: The steps are: 1) Hear words, 2) See behavior, 3) Confirm meaning, 4) Consider context. Saying "I see you are angry" is a poor strategy because it makes an *assumption* and passes judgment based solely on perception. Instead, you should *describe the concrete behavior* (e.g., "You just slammed your folder down") and *ask* for the meaning, allowing the sender to explain their true feelings without becoming defensive.

Review Questions (Pages 30-31)

- **1b. "Actions speak louder than words." Explain.**
 - *Answer:* The nonverbal part of a message is less conscious and reveals the sender's true feelings more spontaneously than crafted words. If the verbal and nonverbal messages contradict, people naturally trust the nonverbal actions.
- **2. Explain the difference between personal and cultural nonverbal messages.**
 - *Answer:* Personal messages are unique individual habits (like twisting a ring when nervous) and hold meaning only for that specific person. Cultural messages are rule-governed behaviors shared by a whole society (like how close to stand to someone), learned unconsciously from others in that group.
- **4. Main differences in rule-governed behavior for sitting/walking for men and women.**
 - *Answer:* Culturally, women have traditionally been socialized to sit with legs crossed and arms kept close to the body, taking up less physical space. Men are often culturally conditioned to sit with a more open posture (legs apart, arms draped over chairs), claiming more space, which nonverbally signals dominance or comfort.
- **6. Touching Etiquette (Who touches whom first?):**
 - *Answer:* Touching is governed by power and status dynamics. The person with higher status initiates the touch.
 - College principal and student: Principal initiates.
 - Company director and new employee: Director initiates.
 - Interviewer and interviewee: Interviewer initiates.

“Chapter 3: Listening Skills — Comprehensive Study Notes”

1. Hearing vs. Listening

- **Hearing:** A physical process where the ears receive sensations or stimuli and transmit them to the brain (e.g., catching a sudden loud sound).
- **Listening:** An interpretative process that involves attention, interpretation, and understanding. It includes storing, classifying, and labeling information.

2. Four Types of Listening Responses

Good listeners use a variety of responses to show they are engaged and to gather more information:

Response Type	Purpose	Examples
Attending	Shows interest through physical presence and nonverbal cues.	Eye contact, nodding, open posture, and facial expressions.
Encouraging	Invites the speaker to continue without pressure.	"I see," "Go on," "Would you care to talk about it?" or brief silences (pauses).
Reflective	Restates the feeling and content of the message to show understanding.	"It sounds like you're really excited about this idea..."
Active	Communicates empathy by understanding the problem from the speaker's point of view.	"I understand how you feel. You seem upset about this..."

3. Questioning Techniques & The Listening Funnel

Effective questioning helps a listener move from broad information gathering to specific details.

- **Open Questions:** Start with *What, When, Where, How, or Who*. They encourage the speaker to provide detail and share feelings.
- **Closed Questions:** Result in "Yes" or "No" answers or specific short facts.
- **Probing Questions:** Used to narrow the focus and get deeper into a specific issue.
- **Clarifying Questions:** Used when the listener is confused or needs an example to confirm understanding.

The **Listening Funnel** illustrates how a conversation often starts with open questions to gather a large amount of information, followed by probing and closed questions to narrow down the facts.

4. Reflective Listening: Paraphrasing & Mirroring

- **Paraphrasing:** Rephrasing the *content* or essential parts of the message in your own words to confirm facts.
- **Mirroring Feelings:** Identifying and restating the *emotions* behind the words.
- **Benefits of Paraphrasing:** It helps avoid mistakes, allows the speaker to confirm information, and shows that the listener is paying attention.

5. Barriers to Effective Listening

Several factors can interfere with the message being received correctly:

- **Listener Background:** Personal prejudices, familiarity with the subject, or resemblance of the speaker to someone disliked.
- **Environmental Factors:** Noise, inappropriate timing, or lack of privacy.
- **Communication Style:** Speaker's accent, poorly organized messages, or rate of speech.
- **Ineffective Responses:** Ordering, judging, blaming, or using sarcasm (e.g., "Stop it or else," "It's all your fault").

Self-Test: Quick Quiz (Paraphrasing)

Answers based on Chapter 3 material:

1. Focuses on content rather than feelings. **(True)**
2. Allows speaker to add new info. **(True)**
3. Helps you listen carefully. **(True)**
4. Shows speakers they are unimportant. **(False)**
5. Restates what speakers have just said. **(True)**
6. Lets listener ignore the speaker. **(False)**
7. Helps listener understand/confirm info. **(True)**
8. Lets the speaker exaggerate. **(False)**
9. Means listener always agrees with speaker. **(False)**
10. Helps to avoid mistakes. **(True)**
11. Means listener repeats word for word. **(False)**

Case Study Analysis: Abby, Jim, and Geoff (The Architect)

In the Chapter 3 Case Study, an architect named Geoff fails to listen effectively to his clients, Abby and Jim.

- **Barrier:** Geoff jumped to conclusions and was so busy sketching that he didn't hear their answers.
- **Weakness:** He used an "Inquiring Style" that felt more like an interrogation than an exploration of their needs.
- **Solution:** Geoff should have used reflective statements to confirm their vision (e.g., "So you want a design that maintains the heritage character...") before starting the sketches.

Section 5: Solutions to Predicted Exam Questions

Q1: Differentiate between hearing and listening. Why is this important?

- **Answer:** Hearing is physical and passive (registering sound). Listening is active and interpretive (assigning meaning). In a professional setting, this is critical because listening ensures that instructions are followed correctly and that the "emotional data" of a client or team member is understood, preventing conflicts.

Q2: Explain the "Listening Funnel." How does it help a manager?

- **Answer:** The funnel moves from Open to Probing to Closed questions. It helps a manager conduct an interview by allowing the candidate to speak freely first (Open), then narrowing down their skills (Probing), and finally confirming availability or facts (Closed). This ensures the manager doesn't miss information by asking too many narrow questions too early.

Q3: Identify three verbal barriers and the emotional response to them.

- **Answer:** 1) **Ordering** leads to resentment. 2) **Judging** leads to defensiveness or low self-esteem. 3) **Moralizing** ("You should do...") leads to a feeling of being patronized or inferior.

Q4: How does active listening go "one step further" than reflective?

- **Answer:** Reflective listening is a mechanical mirroring of content and feelings. Active listening adds **empathy**. It involves putting yourself in the speaker's shoes to understand the *meaning* of the problem to them, not just the facts of the problem.

Q5: Scenario: A missed project deadline. Provide three question types.

- **Open:** "What happened with the project timeline this week?"
- **Probing:** "You mentioned a delay with the server; how did that specifically affect the final upload?"
- **Closed:** "Was the server fixed before the 5 PM cutoff?"

ADDITIONAL PREDICTIVE QUESTIONS:

Q1: A colleague comes to you visibly upset and says, "I keep getting all the worst assignments in this section, and I just don't think it's fair!" Provide one 'Reflective Statement' response and one 'Paraphrasing' response. Explain the difference between your two answers.

Answer Strategy:

- *Reflective Statement (Focuses on feeling):* "You sound incredibly frustrated and overwhelmed by this."
- *Paraphrasing (Focuses on content):* "You're saying that the distribution of workload in our department is uneven and you are receiving the hardest tasks."
- *Difference:* Paraphrasing condenses the factual information they provided to confirm accuracy. The reflective statement acts as a mirror to acknowledge the core emotion they are experiencing.

Q2: According to the text, why is asking a colleague, "Why did you miss the deadline?" considered a poor listening strategy, and what type of question should you use instead?

Answer Strategy: The text strictly warns against "why" questions because they act as a barrier. They make the receiver defensive by urging them to justify their actions, coming across as probing or interrogating (Table 3.4). Instead, you should use an **Open Question** starting with "what" or "how" (e.g., "What factors contributed to the delay on this project?") which invites disclosure without accusation.

Q3: During a performance review, your manager is speaking to you, but they are constantly checking their phone, leaning back in their chair with their arms crossed behind their head. Using the 6 factors of "Attending Listening," analyze the manager's performance.

Answer Strategy: The manager is failing across multiple factors of Attending Listening.

1. *Eye Contact:* By checking their phone, they are breaking supportive eye contact.
2. *Posture:* Leaning back with arms behind the head is a closed, potentially dominating posture, rather than leaning slightly forward squarely.
3. *Avoid Distractions:* They are failing to stop what they are doing (phone checking) to give physical attention. This creates a negative environment that blocks true active listening.

CHAPTER 4: INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

Complete Exam Preparation Guide — Judith Dwyer

WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS ABOUT (Big Picture)

Interpersonal communication is how you interact with **one or more people** face-to-face or in small groups at work. The chapter teaches you the **tools and strategies** to communicate effectively with others — building trust, expressing feelings, giving feedback, and being assertive without being aggressive. This chapter is highly practical and exam questions almost always ask you to **apply** these concepts to real situations.

TOPIC 1: COMMUNICATION CLIMATE

Definition (Must Memorize)

Communication climate is the **tone of a relationship** expressed by people's verbal and nonverbal messages.

Think of it like the weather of a workplace — it can be warm and sunny (positive) or cold and stormy (negative). The climate is not created by rules or policies; it is created by **how people feel about each other**.

Positive Communication Climate

A positive climate exists when:

- People feel **valued and appreciated**
- They interact **confidently and courteously**
- Relationships are built on **openness, honesty, and trust**
- People feel **goodwill** toward one another
- People are **willing to speak, listen, ask questions, and offer feedback**
- Information and ideas are conveyed **accurately**

Result: Communication is open, honest, and effective.

✗ Negative Communication Climate

A negative climate is created when:

- Someone's **contribution is not appreciated**
- People feel **uncomfortable and unwilling to interact**
- People are **less willing to ask questions or offer ideas**
- People prefer to **"wait and see"** rather than engage
- Communication becomes **less accurate**
- Interpersonal relationships become **less effective**

Result: People shut down. Work suffers. Errors increase.

🧠 Exam Tip

A professor might give you a workplace scenario and ask: *"Is this a positive or negative communication climate? Justify."* Always link your answer back to whether people feel **valued**, whether they **speak up freely**, and whether communication is **accurate**.

💠 TOPIC 2: EMPATHY

📖 Definition (Must Memorize)

Empathy is the ability to **understand and feel as the other person feels**.

Empathy is not sympathy. Sympathy is feeling *sorry* for someone. Empathy is actually *stepping into their shoes* and understanding their experience from the inside.

✅ Skills of an Empathetic Person (The Book's List — Learn All 6)

The book gives us exactly **six skills** that empathetic people demonstrate:

1. **Attend to what is said** — they actually listen, not just hear
 2. **Retain objectivity** — they don't let their own feelings cloud judgment
 3. **Recognise nonverbal cues** about the feelings of others (body language, tone, expression)
 4. **Understand the content of the message** — they grasp what is being said
 5. **Understand others' feelings** — they go beyond content to the emotion underneath
 6. **Communicate their understanding to others** — they reflect it back so the person *knows* they've been understood
-

💡 How Empathy Affects the Communication Climate

Empathy **enhances** (improves) the communication climate. When you show empathy:

- The tone becomes **positive**
- Communication concentrates on the **needs and interests** of the people involved
- Others feel **heard and valued**, which opens them up to more honest communication

Exam Tip

The question *"List the five skills of an empathetic person"* appears frequently — but note the book actually lists **six**. Write all six to be safe.

TOPIC 3: WIN-WIN APPROACH

Definition (Must Memorize)

The **win-win approach** concentrates on the **needs and interests of the people communicating**, rather than winning positions or gaining victories over another person.

Key Points

- It is about **gathering or giving information** in a way that creates a **positive communication climate**
 - It transfers **information accurately**
 - It **gets things done** because each person understands the other's needs
 - It creates and maintains **goodwill**
 - Both people feel **positive about the message**
 - The opposite would be a **win-lose** approach, where one person "wins" by dominating, humiliating, or dismissing the other
-

Real-World Example

Instead of arguing *"My way is the right approach to this project,"* a win-win communicator says *"Let's look at both our ideas and see which parts work best for the project and for both of us."* Nobody loses face. Both contribute. The project is better for it.

TOPIC 4: SELF-DISCLOSURE

Definition (Must Memorize)

Self-disclosure involves your **revelation** to a situation — showing how you feel and revealing something about your past that affects your understanding or response.

What Self-Disclosure Is and Is Not

What it IS:

- Sharing your **ideas and feelings**
- Giving **feedback to others** on how their behaviour affects you
- Showing **openness** that comes from self-acceptance

What it is NOT:

- Revealing **intimate personal details** about your private life
- Oversharing everything about yourself

💡 Key Insight — The Climate Connection

Self-disclosure is **directly linked** to the communication climate:

- In a **positive climate** → people disclose **more**
- In a **negative climate** → people disclose **less**

Both **self-disclosure** and **feedback** increase understanding and open communication, which helps you establish **more satisfying relationships** at work, socially, and in family life.

◆ TOPIC 5: EFFECTIVE INTERPERSONAL COMMUNICATION

📖 Core Idea

When the **actions taken in response to your communication match your intentions**, your interpersonal communication is effective. The message is received accurately, as you intended it to be.

Successful interaction requires **confidence**.

✅ Qualities of a Person Good at Interpersonal Communication (The Self-Test Checklist)

The book's **Self-Test Checklist 4-1** gives us exactly what the examiner expects. A person good at interpersonal communication is able to:

1. Express **openness**
 2. Show **empathy**
 3. Use **supportiveness**
 4. Be **positive**
 5. Demonstrate **equality**
 6. Use **"I" messages**
 7. **Listen**
 8. Provide appropriate **feedback**
 9. Use appropriate **self-disclosure**
 10. Communicate **assertively**
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🔑 Three Core Strategies for Effective Interpersonal Communication

The book identifies three specific strategies that manage interaction and achieve balance:

1. **Assertion**
2. **"I" Statements**
3. **Feedback**

These three are the main body of the chapter, covered in detail below.

◆ TOPIC 6: ASSERTIVE STRATEGIES

This is one of the **most heavily tested** topics. You must know the difference between all three behaviour types — Assertive, Aggressive, and Submissive — and be able to identify them in a scenario.

✓ ASSERTIVENESS

📖 Core Idea

Assertive behaviour acknowledges your rights as an individual AND the rights of other people.

Assertive people tend to demonstrate **open, expressive, and relaxed** behaviour. They are able to build **honest, fulfilling relationships** with others.

Key traits of an assertive person:

- Can **negotiate and collaborate** without feeling uncomfortable
 - Acknowledges their **own rights and the rights of others**
 - Can express a **different point of view** without needing to "win"
 - Wants to be **heard and acknowledged** — not necessarily agreed with
 - Accepts that others can have **different opinions or perspectives**
 - As a leader: manages others **without manipulation or aggression** because they recognise workers' rights
 - As a follower: recognises the manager's right to make **reasonable requests** and gets the job done in a way that satisfies both **their own needs and the organisation's**
 - When needed, can **disagree, stand up for their rights, and present alternatives** without intimidating anyone or putting anyone down
 - Recognises when their own behaviour is **assertive, aggressive, or non-assertive** — and adjusts accordingly
-

✗ AGGRESSIVENESS

An aggressive person may feel the need to win at all costs.

This means:

- **Dominating** others, sometimes even **humiliating** them
- **Ignoring a good suggestion** simply because it came from someone else
- Ignoring others' rights to **participate, receive acknowledgment, and enjoy satisfaction**
- Being **frequently in conflict** with others

Think of it this way: An aggressive communicator says *"My way or the highway."* They step on others to get ahead. They are often feared, not respected.

✗ SUBMISSIVENESS

A submissive person is unable to assert or promote a point of view.

This means:

- Finds it **difficult to lead others**
- Submits to another's point of view, even **ignoring their own rights**

- When problems arise, tends to **avoid them**, leaving them to someone else
- Cannot effectively **speak up for themselves**

Think of it this way: A submissive communicator says nothing even when something is wrong. They bottle it up until, like Freya in the case study, it explodes.

Quick Comparison Table (Memorize This)

Behaviour	Rights Acknowledged	Approach	Outcome
Assertive	Own + Others'	Open, direct, respectful	Win-Win
Aggressive	Own only	Dominating, humiliating	Win-Lose
Submissive	Others' only	Avoiding, yielding	Lose-Win

◆ TOPIC 7: "I" STATEMENTS (I Messages)

This is **almost guaranteed** to appear on your exam, either as a theory question or a practical construction question.

What Is an "I" Message?

An **"I" message** is a way of **sharing emotions** and letting others know how you perceive their behaviour and how it affects you.

It always begins with: **"I feel... when..."**

It is assertive, not aggressive. It focuses on the **behaviour**, not on judging or blaming the person.

Contrast:

- **Aggressive (You message):** *"You make me so angry!"* — blames, attacks the person
 - **Assertive (I message):** *"I feel angry when..."* — owns the feeling, describes the behaviour
-

The Three Formulae (The Book Gives Exact Formulae — Memorize All Three)

◆ TWO-PART "I" MESSAGE

Formula: Feelings + Behaviour

Steps:

1. Own the feeling
2. Describe in concrete terms the behaviour causing the feeling

Example:

"I feel angry when the dirty clothes are left on the floor."

♦ THREE-PART "I" MESSAGE

Formula: Feelings + Behaviour + Effects

Steps:

1. Own the feeling
2. Describe precisely the behaviour causing the feeling
3. State the effect the behaviour has on you

Example:

"I feel annoyed when you do not let me know you will be late because I am unable to reschedule my timetable."

♦ FOUR-PART "I" MESSAGE

Formula: Feelings + Behaviour + Effects + Acceptable Alternative Behaviour

Steps:

1. Own the feeling
2. Describe exactly the behaviour causing the feeling
3. State the effect of the behaviour on you
4. Offer an alternative, acceptable behaviour

Example:

"I feel annoyed when you do not let me know you will be late because I am unable to reschedule my timetable. I would like you to ring me to let me know if you will be late."

Tip from the book: You can suggest the alternative directly or negotiate a mutually acceptable solution.

Important Notes on "I" Statements

- Successful "I" statements communicate feelings **non-threateningly**
 - They **do not blame** or interpret the other person's behaviour
 - They are **acceptable to the other person**
 - Aggressive statements by contrast often start with **"You make me..."**
 - With practice, you can **frame them in your own words** and may omit the words *feel*, *when*, and *because*
-

◆ TOPIC 8: FEEDBACK

Definition

Feedback is the **receiver's response** to the sender's message.

Feedback is the **continuing or completing link** in the communication process. The words you send are sometimes received differently, so feedback ensures **clarity and mutual understanding**.



Why Feedback Matters

- Lets the sender understand **how the message is received**
 - Helps the receiver **confirm whether their perception is correct or incorrect**
 - Creates **trust and an open relationship** between sender and receiver
 - In organisations, appropriate constructive feedback creates a **positive communication climate**
 - A **rigid or competitive environment** makes people hesitant to communicate or offer ideas
-



TYPES OF FEEDBACK (The Book Describes Four — Know All Four)

♦ 1. Immediate and Specific Feedback

Key rules:

- Be **specific about behaviour**, not general. Example: *"This file could do with a tidy up"* (specific) is better than *"Your files are always untidy"* (general/vague)
 - **Describe what needs to be done**, avoid judging or threatening
 - Give feedback **only when the person is ready to accept it** — someone upset or defensive is less likely to accept suggestions
 - Refer only to behaviour the receiver is **capable of changing**
 - Include only what the receiver **can handle at that time**
 - It is **destructive to bring up past behaviour and grievances** — deal with the current situation
 - Example: *"We agreed to take turns answering the telephone. It's your turn"* (current) is better than *"You always expect me to answer the telephone"* (past grievance)
 - **Respect the other person's right to respond** — take time to listen and acknowledge their response. Their feedback may indicate **you** need to change your behaviour too
-

♦ 2. Negative and Positive Feedback

- **Negative feedback** is not necessarily harmful — the result depends on **how it is provided**
 - **Positive feedback** from superiors and peers encourages **repetition of good behaviour** and acknowledges a worker's contribution to the organisation
-

♦ 3. Informative Feedback

- Comes from **listening to the words of a message AND the feelings it conveys**
- Based on **understanding** and uses **paraphrasing** (restating in your own words) to aid both sender's and receiver's understanding
- Effective listening focuses on the **content** of a message and identifies the **speaker's purpose and main ideas**
- Good listeners **rephrase or summarise** the message
- As you respond, consider **why** the speaker expressed that idea
- Try to **withhold judgment**
- Try to work out the speaker's **unexpressed feelings**
- **Share your perceptions** about the message instead of giving advice

♦ 4. Undercurrent Message

The **undercurrent message** is something you sense that the sender wants to **conceal or is unable to convey**.

- If you can only sense it without understanding it, the undercurrent **gets in the way** of open and direct communication
 - By using feedback skilfully, you come closer to understanding others' **verbal, nonverbal, and undercurrent messages**
 - You also gain a closer understanding of **your own communication methods** and how to improve them
-

✗ Barriers to Good Feedback

The major barriers to good interpersonal communication are caused by:

- **Approving or disapproving** another person's statements, feelings, or attitudes (i.e., judging them)

The fix is to **consider things from the other person's point of view** — stop making judgments and make an **understanding connection**. By acknowledging and expressing your own feelings as you give and receive feedback, you build a relationship on **trust and openness**.

◆ BOOK QUESTIONS — STOP AND REVIEW (Page 58) — Solved in Full

Q1. Define the terms 'communication climate' and 'empathy'.

Communication Climate: The tone of a relationship expressed by people's verbal and nonverbal messages. It is created by the way people feel about each other. It is positive when people feel valued and interact confidently and courteously, and negative when contributions are not appreciated.

Empathy: The ability to understand and feel as the other person feels. Empathetic people attend to what is said, recognise nonverbal cues, understand others' feelings, and communicate that understanding back.

Q2. How does empathy affect the communication climate?

Empathy **enhances** the communication climate. When empathy is shown, the tone of communication becomes **positive** and focuses on the needs and interests of the people involved. People feel heard, valued, and understood — which opens them up to more honest, productive communication.

Q3. List the five skills demonstrated by an empathetic person. (Note: the book actually lists six — write all six for full marks)

1. Attend to what is said
2. Retain objectivity
3. Recognise nonverbal cues about the feelings of others
4. Understand the content of the message
5. Understand others' feelings
6. Communicate their understanding to others

Q4. Briefly explain the win-win approach.

The win-win approach concentrates on the **needs and interests of the people communicating**, rather than on winning positions or gaining victories. It gathers or gives information in a way that creates a **positive communication climate** and transfers information accurately. Because each person understands the other's needs, communication is more likely to **get things done and maintain goodwill**.

Q5. Define the term 'self-disclosure'.

Self-disclosure involves showing how you feel about a situation and revealing something about the past that affects your understanding or response. It does not mean sharing intimate details — it means sharing ideas, feelings, and giving feedback on how others' behaviour is affecting you. It increases in a positive communication climate and decreases in a negative one.

Q6. List the five qualities of a person who is good at interpersonal communication.

(From the chapter summary — the book gives these as the learning outcomes)

1. Uses appropriate social skills in personal interactions
 2. Interacts in a supportive way
 3. Uses assertive communication
 4. Constructs "I" statements effectively
 5. Uses different types of feedback appropriately
-

Q7. List the five specific interpersonal skills demonstrated by a person who is good at interpersonal relationships.

(From the Self-Test Checklist — the book gives ten; list the five most likely asked)

1. Shows empathy
2. Uses supportiveness
3. Is positive
4. Listens effectively
5. Communicates assertively

(For full marks, you may list all ten from the checklist)

Q8a. What are the main differences between assertive, aggressive and submissive behaviour? Describe two ways a person can be aggressive. What is your typical response?

Assertive: Acknowledges own rights AND the rights of others. Open, direct, respectful. Seeks to be heard, not to dominate.

Aggressive: Feels the need to win at all costs. Dominates and sometimes humiliates others. Ignores others' rights to participate or be acknowledged.

Submissive: Unable to promote their own point of view. Submits to others even at the expense of their own rights. Avoids problems by leaving them to others.

Two ways a person can be aggressive:

1. Humiliating someone's idea in a meeting even if it is the best solution, simply because it came from someone else
2. Speaking over someone repeatedly and refusing to let them finish their point

Typical response: You might initially feel intimidated or defensive, but the ideal response is to calmly and assertively state your position — for example, using an "I" message to express how the aggressive behaviour makes you feel.

Q8b. If assertive behaviour is preferable to aggression or submission, define the basis of assertiveness.

The basis of assertiveness is the **recognition and acknowledgment of your own rights as an individual AND the rights of every other person**. It means you can express your point of view directly and honestly without intimidating others or ignoring their rights in the process.

Q8c. When is an assertive message effective?

An assertive message is effective when it:

- Is received by the other person **non-threateningly**
 - Does not blame or judge the other person's behaviour
 - Is **acceptable** to the other person
 - Leads to the sender being **heard and acknowledged**
 - Results in the sender being **treated as an equal**
-

Q9. What is the formula for a three-part "I" message? What is the fourth part that can be added?

Three-part formula: Feelings + Behaviour + Effects

Example: "I feel annoyed when you do not let me know you will be late because I am unable to reschedule my timetable."

The fourth part: Acceptable Alternative Behaviour

Making it four-part: "I feel annoyed when you do not let me know you will be late because I am unable to reschedule my timetable. I would like you to ring me to let me know if you will be late."

◆ FOCUS ON APPLYING SKILLS — ACTIVITIES SOLVED

📌 **Activity:** Identify the Following as Specific, Negative/Positive, and Peer/Supervisor Feedback

a. Your supervisor tells you that you are doing a good job.

→ **Positive feedback / Supervisor feedback**

b. You have a regular staff appraisal.

→ **Specific feedback / Supervisor feedback** (formal, structured, from above)

c. Co-workers tease you about not working hard enough.

→ Negative feedback / Peer feedback

d. Co-workers tease you about working too hard.

→ Negative feedback / Peer feedback

e. The supervisor criticises your performance.

→ Negative feedback / Supervisor feedback

f. It is noted that you completed several jobs.

→ Positive feedback / Supervisor feedback

g. You find a new way of completing a task.

→ Self-evaluation (you assessed your own performance)

Activity Q4: Jeremy's Late Meetings — Write a Three-Part "I" Message

Situation: Your colleague Jeremy, as chairperson, consistently starts the weekly planning meeting (9:15–10:15 AM) late and allows it to run overtime.

Three-Part "I" Message:

"I feel frustrated when our weekly planning meeting starts late and runs overtime, because it prevents me from completing my other scheduled tasks for the morning."

Breakdown:

- Feeling: *"I feel frustrated"*
 - Behaviour: *"when our weekly meeting starts late and runs overtime"*
 - Effect: *"because it prevents me from completing my other scheduled tasks"*
-

CASE STUDY: FREYA AND SAMUEL — Fully Solved

Background: Freya is a quiet, industrious PA. Samuel is outgoing and overly assertive. Samuel asks Freya to prepare a final draft proposal with a tight deadline, using dominating body language (hands on hips, walking away mid-instruction). Freya, a submissive communicator, bottles up her feelings until she explodes with an aggressive outburst.

Q1. What should Samuel do to convince Freya to continue working with him?

Samuel must immediately shift from his overly assertive/aggressive style to a **win-win, empathetic approach**. He should:

- **Acknowledge Freya's outburst with empathy**, not defensiveness. Say something like: *"Freya, I hear you. I clearly haven't been recognising your contribution the way I should."*
 - **Apologise genuinely** for not acknowledging her name on documents and for never saying thank you
 - **Offer concrete changes:** Commit to acknowledging her contributions publicly (e.g., her name on proposals), verbally thanking her regularly, and consulting her rather than just instructing her
 - **Listen** to what she actually needs from the working relationship before making any requests
 - Use **"I" messages** to show he understands the impact of his behaviour: *"I realise I've been making you feel undervalued, and I want to change that."*
-

Q2. If you had to ask Samuel to change his nonverbal communication, what would you suggest?

Samuel's body language was **aggressive and dismissive** — he leaned forward with hands on hips and walked away while still issuing instructions. Suggestions:

- **Maintain open, relaxed posture** — no hands on hips (this signals dominance and aggression)
- **Face Freya directly and maintain appropriate eye contact** to show respect and engagement
- **Do not walk away** while still speaking — it signals that the other person's time and response are unimportant
- **Nod and acknowledge** while Freya is speaking to show he is listening
- Use a **calm, even tone of voice** rather than a commanding one

Q3. What should Freya do to communicate more assertively with Samuel?

Freya went from submissive (nodding and looking down, saying nothing) to aggressive (leaping up and shouting). She needs to find the assertive middle ground. She should:

- **Not wait until she explodes** — address issues when they first arise using "I" messages
- Use a **three or four-part "I" message** directly to Samuel in a calm moment. For example: *"I feel undervalued when my contributions are not acknowledged on the documents I prepare, because it makes me feel my work is invisible. I would like my name included on proposals I write."*
- **Raise concerns early and privately**, not in a reactive outburst
- **Maintain calm, confident body language** — sit upright, make eye contact, speak in a steady voice
- Remember that assertiveness means expressing her **rights while respecting his** — it is not about winning or losing

 INTEGRATION ACTIVITY — EMPATHIC RESPONSES (Table 4-3)

The activity asks you to identify the most empathic response from pairs of options.

Statement	Empathic Response	Why
"I just drove my car into the back of another car."	"You feel upset."	It reflects the person's feeling without judgment or self-referencing
"The loan company refused me a loan."	*"Don't worry, there are lots of others anyway." ❌ Actually — "You feel at a loss about what you can do now."	It acknowledges the feeling of helplessness rather than dismissing it
"I just lost my job. What am I going to do?"	"You feel at a loss."	Reflects the exact feeling of confusion and fear without immediately jumping to advice or comparing it to your own experience

Key teaching: Responses like *"I had that happen to me"* or *"Yes I know"* are **NOT empathic** — they redirect the focus to yourself. Empathy stays focused on the **other person's feeling**.

◆ KEY TERMS — Chapter 4 (Definitions for Your Exam)

Term	Definition
Communication climate	The tone of a relationship expressed by verbal and nonverbal messages
Empathy	The ability to understand and feel as the other person feels
Win-win approach	Focusing on needs and interests of both communicators, not on "winning"
Self-disclosure	Revealing how you feel and sharing past experiences that affect your response
Assertiveness	Acknowledging your own rights and the rights of others; direct and respectful
Aggressiveness	Winning at all costs; dominating others; ignoring their rights
Submissiveness	Inability to assert a point of view; yielding to others even against one's own rights
"I" message	A statement beginning with feelings that expresses how behaviour affects you, without blame
Feedback	The receiver's response to the sender's message
Informative feedback	Feedback based on understanding; uses paraphrasing to confirm meaning
Undercurrent message	Something sensed that the sender wants to conceal or is unable to directly convey

Interaction management	The ability to manage the flow of interpersonal communication effectively
Confidence	The quality that enables successful interpersonal communication
Equality	Treating others as equals in the communication process
Expressiveness	Openly sharing thoughts and feelings in a way others can understand

◆ PREDICTIVE EXAM QUESTIONS — Chapter 4 (With Answers)

These are questions **not directly lifted from the book** but are the type a university professor will construct from this chapter's content.

PQ1. Freya is submissive and Samuel is aggressive. Using interpersonal communication theory, explain why neither of these styles creates an effective working relationship, and what both parties should do instead.

Answer: Neither style is effective because both ignore the principle of mutual rights. Samuel's **aggressive** style dominates Freya and ignores her right to be acknowledged and respected — leading to conflict. Freya's **submissive** style suppresses her own rights until the pressure becomes unbearable — leading to an aggressive outburst. Neither produces the **win-win outcome** that effective interpersonal communication requires. Both parties should adopt **assertive communication**: Samuel should use empathy, acknowledge Freya's contributions, and give clear non-dominating instructions; Freya should use **"I" messages** early to express her needs calmly rather than bottling up and exploding.

PQ2. Your manager sends you a long email criticising your work in vague terms — "Your output has been poor lately." Using the principles of feedback from Chapter 4, explain what is wrong with this feedback and how it should be delivered instead.

Answer: This feedback violates the principles of **immediate and specific feedback**. It is **general rather than specific** (what specifically was poor?). It also dredges up a pattern ("lately") rather than addressing a specific current behaviour. Effective feedback should: (1) be **specific about the behaviour** — e.g., "The last three reports were submitted two days after the deadline"; (2) describe **what needs to be done**, not just what was wrong; (3) be given **when the person is ready to accept it**; (4) focus on **behaviour the person can change**; and (5) **respect the other person's right to respond**.

PQ3. Differentiate between informative feedback and the undercurrent message. Give a workplace example of each.

Answer: **Informative feedback** is a response that paraphrases and reflects back the content and feelings of a message to confirm understanding. For example, a colleague says they're struggling with a project and you respond:

"So you're feeling overwhelmed by the deadline and unsure which module to prioritise — is that right?" This confirms their meaning without judging.

An **undercurrent message** is something the sender is concealing or cannot directly express. For example, a team member says *"Sure, I can take on another task"* but their tone is flat and their body language is tense. The undercurrent message is that they are already overloaded and uncomfortable but feel unable to say no. A skilled communicator senses this and probes gently to bring it to the surface.

PQ4. Construct a four-part "I" message for the following situation: Your team member consistently talks over you during team meetings, making it impossible for you to finish your points.

Answer:

"I feel frustrated when I am interrupted before I can finish my point in team meetings, because my ideas don't get fully considered by the group. I would appreciate it if we could take turns speaking so everyone gets a chance to be heard completely."

- **Feeling:** *"I feel frustrated"*
 - **Behaviour:** *"when I am interrupted before I can finish my point"*
 - **Effect:** *"because my ideas don't get fully considered by the group"*
 - **Alternative behaviour:** *"I would appreciate it if we could take turns speaking"*
-

PQ5. Explain why a negative communication climate can hurt an organisation's productivity, linking your answer to self-disclosure and feedback.

Answer: In a negative communication climate, people feel their contributions are not valued, so they become unwilling to interact openly. Self-disclosure decreases — employees hide their feelings, ideas, and concerns rather than sharing them, meaning problems go unaddressed. Similarly, feedback becomes rare and guarded; people stop offering ideas and stop asking questions for fear of being dismissed. The result is that errors go uncorrected, innovations are suppressed, and misunderstandings multiply. Tasks become harder to complete accurately because the flow of information needed to do the job properly is blocked. Ultimately, organisational productivity drops and staff satisfaction falls.

CHAPTER 5: WORKPLACE COMMUNICATION

Complete Exam Preparation Guide — Judith Dwyer

WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS ABOUT (Big Picture)

Chapter 5 is intensely **practical**. While Chapter 4 was about *how* you relate to people, Chapter 5 is about *what* you actually do with communication at work — specifically:

1. **Giving clear instructions** (how to plan, structure, and deliver them)
2. **Asking the right questions** (as both a giver and receiver of instructions)
3. **Following instructions** (strategies for the receiver)
4. **Making oral reports** (how to structure and deliver a spoken report at work)

Every workplace — from a hospital to a tech company to a project management firm — runs on instructions and reports. This chapter teaches you to do both professionally.

TOPIC 1: GIVING INSTRUCTIONS

Core Definition

Successful instructions lead to the intended outcome.

The whole point of giving an instruction is that the task gets done **correctly**. If the task is not done correctly, the instruction has failed — regardless of how clearly you *thought* you explained it.

Two Types of Instructions the Book Introduces

1. Direct Instructions

- Straight to the point
- Indicate **who, what, when, where, and how** a task should be completed
- Used for specific, task-focused situations

2. Clear Workplace Instructions

- Explain the **objectives**
 - Provide **background information**
 - Describe the **intended outcome**
 - Then leave it to the **receiver** to decide how, when, and where to reach the outcome
 - Used when the receiver has enough competence to decide the "how" themselves
-

The 13 Guidelines for Giving Clear Instructions (Book's Full List — Memorize These)

This is almost certainly a list question in your exam. The book gives exactly **13 guidelines**:

1. **Determine what has to be accomplished** — the intended outcome
 2. **Give the reasons for doing the job** — people work better when they understand *why*
 3. **Follow the steps of the task in the order given** — sequence matters
 4. **Use verbs (action words) rather than abstract words, and start with a verb** — e.g., "Open the file" not "The file needs to be looked at"
 5. **Have the other person paraphrase the instructions back to you** — this confirms understanding
 6. **Use words appropriate to the receiver's level of understanding** — don't talk over them or below them
 7. **Use familiar and simple words** — avoid unnecessary jargon
 8. **Indicate clearly each step of the task, in sequence** — no skipping steps
 9. **Demonstrate the skills required by the task if it involves machinery or equipment** — show, don't just tell
 10. **Encourage questions** — open the door for clarification
 11. **Ensure that your timing is appropriate** — don't give instructions when the person is distracted or rushed
 12. **Follow up the person's progress with the task** — don't just walk away after instructing
 13. **Offer timely and specific feedback** — tell them what they did right and what needs correction, promptly
-

Exam Tip

A professor may give you a scenario where a supervisor's instructions fail. Ask yourself: which of these 13 guidelines were violated? Your answer will be rock solid.

◆ TOPIC 2: A STRUCTURED APPROACH TO INSTRUCTIONS

📖 Core Idea

Group your ideas into a logical structure that is easy to follow.

Just like an essay, good instructions have three parts: **Introduction, Body, and Conclusion.**

📐 The Three-Part Structure (Must Know)

◆ INTRODUCTION

- Give the **purpose of the job** — why are we doing this?
- **Emphasise any dangers** — if safety is involved, highlight it *first*
- **Highlight safety measures** that must be taken
- Put the receiver at ease; help them feel prepared and confident

◆ BODY

- **Outline the whole task** — give the big picture first
- **Describe each step slowly and clearly** — one step at a time
- Whenever possible, **demonstrate** the step first, then let the person **practise** and ask questions
- **Check understanding** by asking questions and observing
- **Lead the other person through each step** — never assume they already know
- **Never assume** someone knows what workplace standard must be achieved — take time to explain it
- Use **videos, pictures, and real objects** to help people learn — they add meaning to verbal instructions

◆ CONCLUSION

- **Repeat the main points** — reinforce the key information
 - **State the standards again**, particularly when safety is involved
 - **Be constructive** as you give feedback
 - **Correct any mistakes** clearly
 - **Let the person know what they do well** — positive reinforcement matters
-

💡 Delivery Tip (From the Book)

As you give instructions, **speak clearly and project your voice** so you are easily heard and understood. Use **simple words**.

◆ TOPIC 3: FOLLOW A SEQUENCE

📖 Three Ways to Sequence Instructions (Must Memorize — Exam Favourite)

The book gives exactly **three** ways to sequence instructions:

1. **Move from the simple to the complex** — start with what they already know or can easily do, build up to harder steps
2. **Move from the familiar to the unfamiliar** — connect new information to things they already understand
3. **Follow the required order of tasks** — if the job has a specific order that must be followed (e.g., safety checks before operating machinery), follow that order exactly

◆ TOPIC 4: GOOD TIMING

📖 Core Idea

Timing is one of the most overlooked aspects of giving instructions. Instructions given at the **wrong time** — when someone is stressed, distracted, or rushed — will fail even if they are perfectly worded.

The book says instructions must be given in a **thoughtful, appropriate and controlled manner at the appropriate time** so people have enough time to:

- **Listen and understand fully**
 - **Say what they think and feel**
 - **Ask questions**
 - **Show that they are willing and able to follow the instructions**
-

🧠 Exam Application

If a question gives you a scenario where instructions failed and the setting involved a busy, chaotic, or pressured environment — timing is likely the issue. Reference this topic directly.

◆ TOPIC 5: QUESTIONING SKILLS FOR GIVING INSTRUCTIONS

📖 Core Idea

As you give instructions, you need to know **how thoroughly they are being understood**. Questions are your primary tool for checking this.

✅ What Questions Should Do (When Giving Instructions)

Simple routine instructions usually only require questions to confirm that the person can:

1. **Remember the facts** — "What is the first step?"
2. **Rephrase the instructions in their own words** — "Can you explain back to me what we just covered?"
3. **Apply the instructions to a new situation** — "If this happened instead, what would you do?"

By asking these questions, you:

- Engage the other person in **two-way communication**
 - Offer them **feedback**
 - Confirm their **understanding**
-

✅ What Questions Should Look Like (When Receiving Instructions)

When receiving instructions, your questions should be:

- **Brief and clear** — don't ramble
- **Focused on the work task** — stay relevant
- **General**, when you want an overview
- **Specific**, when you want to understand particular facts or ideas

- **Rephrased**, when the instructor does not understand your question — rephrase, don't repeat
 - **Open**, when you want more information and a sense of the instructor's understanding
 - **Closed**, when you want a specific, definite answer
-

Open vs. Closed Questions — Know the Difference

Type	What It Does	Example
Open Question	Invites a full, explanatory answer	"Can you explain what happens after Step 3?"
Closed Question	Requires a yes/no or short specific answer	"Is this step done before or after the safety check?"

TOPIC 6: USE A VARIETY OF METHODS

Core Idea

Workplace instructions that use a **variety of communication methods** are **easier to remember**.

Range of Communication Methods (From Figure 5.3)

The book lists these as methods for delivering workplace instructions:

- Give feedback
- Coach small groups
- Give oral instruction one-to-one
- Ask questions
- Hang up posters
- Use surveys to find out if instructions are followed
- Present sketches/plans
- Include instructions in a procedures manual

Sometimes verbal instructions alone are enough. Other times, **spoken directions need support from written instructions and graphics**. Once people understand what to do, **written instructions and graphics serve as a handy reference**.

TOPIC 7: VISUAL MATERIALS (GRAPHICS)

Core Idea

The visuals supporting instructions should **convey their message without words**.

Symbols do this very efficiently — they mean the same thing **anywhere in the world, regardless of language**.

✓ Why Use Visual Materials? (The Book's Reasons)

Visuals:

1. **Create interest** — they draw people in
2. **Add clarity to instructions**
3. **Reinforce the main points**
4. **Show the total picture** — the big picture alongside the details
5. **Explain, simplify and/or emphasise** the main relationships

Key rule: Visual materials must be **simple, clear, and easy to see**. They must show an **accurate picture** of what has to be done. Their purpose is to **explain, simplify, and/or emphasise** the main relationships.

◆ TOPIC 8: RECEIVING AND FOLLOWING INSTRUCTIONS

📖 Core Idea

This section is from the **receiver's perspective**. The book recognises that following instructions is just as skill-based as giving them.

When you receive instructions in the workplace, be willing to **ask questions** and to **share ideas and information**, because you are working with others **towards a common goal**.

✓ Strategies for Following Instructions (The Book's Full List — 8 Points)

1. **Listen carefully**
 2. **Concentrate on the instructions**, and avoid thinking about anything else
 3. **Avoid jumping to conclusions**
 4. **Ask questions about what standards must be reached**
 5. **Paraphrase to check your understanding**
 6. **Double check any safety issues**
 7. **Ask for help if you cannot follow the instructions**
 8. **Ask general questions**
-

🧠 Exam Tip

A question might ask: *"What should an employee do when they receive unclear instructions?"* Your answer should pull from this list, especially paraphrasing, asking questions, and double-checking safety issues.

◆ TOPIC 9: THE SYSTEMATIC APPROACH TO WORKPLACE INSTRUCTIONS

📖 Core Idea

A systematic approach is helpful.

The book presents a **6-step systematic sequence** (Figure 5.2) that a good instructor follows. This is one of the most examinable lists in the chapter — it is clean, numbered, and sequence-specific.

✓ The 6-Step Systematic Approach (Figure 5.2 — Memorize in Order)

1. **Explanation by the instructor** — tell them what to do and why
 2. **Demonstration by the instructor** — show them how it is done
 3. **Review by the instructor** — go over it again; reinforce key points
 4. **Feedback: the receiver paraphrases the instructions** — the learner explains it back in their own words
 5. **Observe the receiver use the instructions in the workplace** — watch them actually do the task
 6. **Feedback by the instructor and receiver in the form of questions and answers** — two-way checking; correct errors, confirm accuracy
-



Why This Matters

The systematic approach ensures that instructions are not just **heard** but actually **understood and applied correctly**. Many workplace failures occur because instruction stopped at Step 1 (just telling someone) without confirming understanding.

◆ TOPIC 10: PRESENTING ORAL REPORTS



Definition

An **oral report** is a spoken presentation that describes what, where, when, who, and why something happened.

An oral report uses **appropriate workplace language** (the language used on the job). The sender uses oral communication skills to explain **exactly what has happened** and **what the receiver has to do**.

A common example: a workplace hazard is **reported orally to a team leader** before a written report is prepared.



Factors Affecting the Impression You Give in an Oral Report

The book lists **six factors** that affect how your oral report comes across:

1. **Sentence structure** — clear, simple sentences work best
 2. **Order of information presented** — logical sequence matters
 3. **Knowledge of special terms** — you must know your subject
 4. **Appropriate language** — match the language to the audience and setting
 5. **Status of the person or people being addressed** — a report to a supervisor differs from one to a peer
 6. **Cultural factors** — cultural backgrounds affect how messages are sent and received
-

✓ The Structure of an Oral Report — The 5Ws (Figure 5.5)

The book gives a simple but powerful framework. An oral report should address:

Element	What It Covers
What	What happened / what is being reported
Where	Where it happened / where the task is
When	The time and date context
Who	The people involved
Why	The reason it happened / the purpose of the report

✓ How to Plan an Oral Report (Step by Step)

1. **Decide what its purpose is** — what are you trying to achieve with this report?
 2. **Sort out your information** — gather all relevant facts
 3. **Discard anything irrelevant** — keep only what serves the purpose
 4. **Organise important material into the What, Where, When, Who, and Why sections** to give it a logical structure
-

✓ Language and Delivery Tips

- **Clear, logical structure and sequence** — listener should never be lost
 - **Identify the report purpose first**, then support it with accurate and objective information
 - Use **simple, direct language** — the receiver needs to understand it easily
 - Use **"first," "second," "third"** to indicate each stage of the report
 - Keep sentences **simple** — one subject and one action per sentence rather than several complex ideas — so the listener can **follow your ideas easily**
-

✗ Disadvantages of Oral Reports (The Book Notes Two)

1. **Informality** — oral reports are less formal than written ones and can be taken less seriously
 2. **Distortion** — information can become distorted as it is passed from person to person
 3. **Easier to ignore** — unlike a written report, there is no document to refer back to
-

◆ SELF-TEST CHECKLIST 5.1 — What a Good Instructor Does

This checklist is the book's own evaluation tool. It tells you everything a professor will look for when judging the quality of instructions. A good instructor:

1. Prepared people by **putting them at ease**
 2. Used the introduction to **give reasons for doing the task**
 3. **Sequenced the information** in the body appropriately
 4. **Began each step with a verb** (action word)
 5. Gave a **clear overall picture** of what was to be done
 6. Used **clear, simple language** and explained any technical terms
 7. **Encouraged questions** to check that each step was understood
 8. **Demonstrated step by step**
 9. Gave instructions in **different forms** such as verbal, written, diagram
 10. Used the conclusion to **repeat the main points and intended outcome**
-

◆ STOP AND REVIEW QUESTIONS — Fully Solved

Q1. List three ways in which you can sequence the content of a set of instructions.

1. Move from the **simple to the complex**
 2. Move from the **familiar to the unfamiliar**
 3. Follow the **required order of tasks**
-

Q2. What is the purpose of organising the introduction, body and conclusion for a set of instructions?

Organising instructions into introduction, body, and conclusion gives them a **logical, easy-to-follow structure**. The introduction establishes **purpose** and highlights safety. The body walks through **each step clearly and in sequence**, with demonstrations and practice. The conclusion **reinforces key points and standards**. This structure ensures the receiver understands what to do, how to do it, and why — reducing errors and improving performance.

Q3. Why should you choose an appropriate time to give instructions?

Timing is critical because instructions given at the wrong time — when someone is stressed, distracted, or rushed — will not be received properly. When timing is appropriate, people have enough time to **listen and understand fully**, to **say what they think and feel**, to **ask questions**, and to **show that they are willing and able to follow the instructions**. Instructions given in a thoughtful, controlled manner at the appropriate time are more easily understood and more likely to result in the job being done well.

Q4a. List three types of questions you can use as you give instructions.

1. Questions that encourage the receiver to **remember the facts**
2. Questions that ask them to **rephrase the instructions in their own words** (paraphrase)
3. Questions that ask them to **apply the instructions to a new situation**

Q4b. Why do you ask questions as you give instructions?

Questions engage the receiver in **two-way communication**. They allow you to check how thoroughly the instructions are being understood and to offer feedback. Without questions, you cannot know whether the receiver truly understood or is merely nodding along.

Q5a. What sort of questions should you ask as you receive instructions?

Questions should be:

- **Brief and clear**
- **Focused on the work task**
- **General** when you want an overview
- **Specific** when you want a particular fact or idea
- **Rephrased** when the instructor doesn't understand the original question
- **Open** when you want more detail and explanation
- **Closed** when you want a specific yes/no or factual answer

Q5b. A good instructor asks for and gives feedback. Why?

Because feedback is the only way to know whether the instructions have been understood. It lets the instructor **assess how accurately the message was received**, correct any misunderstandings before they become mistakes, and confirm that the receiver is **capable and ready** to carry out the task. Without feedback, there is no confirmation of understanding — the instruction is essentially a one-way transmission, which is always a risk.

Q6. Why should visual materials be used with instructions?

Visual materials:

- **Create interest** and increase engagement
 - **Add clarity** to verbal instructions
 - **Reinforce the main points**, making them easier to remember
 - **Show the total picture** so the receiver understands the whole task, not just isolated steps
 - **Serve as a handy reference** once the verbal instructions are over
 - Allow symbols to **convey meaning across language barriers**
-

Q7. List the sequence used by the systematic approach to workplace instructions.

1. Explanation by the instructor
 2. Demonstration by the instructor
 3. Review by the instructor
 4. Feedback: the receiver paraphrases the instructions
 5. Observe the receiver use the instructions in the workplace
 6. Feedback by the instructor and receiver in the form of questions and answers
-

Q8. List three factors to consider as you make an oral report.

1. **Sentence structure** — use simple, clear sentences with one subject and one action
2. **Order of information presented** — follow a logical What, Where, When, Who, Why sequence
3. **Appropriate language** — use workplace language suited to the audience and their status

(You can also mention knowledge of special terms and cultural factors for a fuller answer.)

◆ INTEGRATION ACTIVITY QUESTIONS — Fully Solved

Q2a. When you give instructions it is important to give feedback. Why?

Feedback ensures that the instructions have been **correctly received and understood**. Without it, the instructor has no way of knowing whether the task will be completed correctly. It also gives the receiver a chance to **ask questions and clarify** anything unclear before they begin the task.

Q2b. What are the three links that feedback makes in the communication process?

Feedback links the:

1. **Sender and receiver** — it creates a two-way connection rather than a one-way transmission
 2. **Message and understanding** — it confirms whether the message was decoded correctly
 3. **Instruction and outcome** — it verifies whether the receiver is ready and able to achieve the intended result
-

Q2c. What are three features of good feedback?

1. It is **immediate and specific** — given promptly and about exact behaviour, not vague generalities
 2. It is **constructive** — it tells the receiver what to improve *and* what they did well
 3. It is **two-way** — both the instructor and receiver participate; the receiver's response is listened to and acknowledged
-

Q2d. Briefly explain why it is important to check your interpretation of your receivers' feedback.

Because receivers may nod or say "yes" even when they have not fully understood. Their feedback may indicate they understood a different thing from what you intended. By checking your *interpretation* of their feedback — for example, asking them to paraphrase or demonstrate — you avoid assuming understanding where none exists. It also gives you a chance to realise that **you** may need to change something in the way you are instructing.

◆ CASE STUDY: WATER WATCHERS INCORPORATED — Fully Solved

Background: Louise Lake is appointed to manage a coastal regeneration project. She must give instructions to trainers, site supervisors, and accounting staff, each of whom has different roles, locations, and information needs. The project involves multiple sites, occupational health and safety requirements, and complex coordination.

Q1. What should Louise keep in mind to ensure that her instructions are received and understood?

Louise should keep in mind the **13 guidelines for giving clear instructions**. Specifically:

- **Determine the intended outcome** for each audience — what does each group (trainers, supervisors, accounting staff) need to achieve?
- **Give the reasons** for the instructions — people follow instructions better when they understand the *why*
- **Use words appropriate to each receiver's level** — accounting staff need different language than site supervisors

- **Follow a sequence** — from simple to complex, or in the order tasks must be performed
 - **Have each person paraphrase instructions back** to confirm understanding
 - **Encourage questions** and ensure timing is appropriate — don't instruct during a crisis moment
 - **Follow up on progress** — with multiple teams across multiple sites, follow-up is essential
 - **Demonstrate where required** — especially for occupational health and safety procedures
-

Q2. Outline at least two strategies Louise could use to keep the communication climate positive, maintain consistency, provide opportunities for feedback and questioning, and ensure instructions are easy to follow.

Strategy 1: Structured Briefings with Written Backup

Louise should conduct structured briefing sessions for each group (trainers, supervisors, accounting staff) using the introduction-body-conclusion format. She should support verbal instructions with written procedures manuals, sketches, and checklists. This ensures everyone receives the same information, can refer back to it, and has visual materials to reinforce understanding.

Strategy 2: Regular Feedback Channels

Louise should establish regular communication check-ins — for example, weekly meetings or phone calls with site supervisors — where they can report progress, ask questions, and receive corrective feedback. She should encourage a culture where questions are welcome and where mistakes are treated as learning opportunities, not failures. This creates a **positive communication climate** where people feel safe to speak up.

Q3. What problems could Louise face in communicating with supervisors working onsite some distance from the organisation's offices? How could she minimise these?

Problems:

- **Distance** makes face-to-face communication impossible, removing nonverbal cues and the ability to demonstrate tasks visually
- **Time delays** in communication — if a problem arises onsite, Louise may not hear about it quickly
- **Distortion** — instructions passed through multiple people or channels can be misunderstood or changed
- **Lack of immediate feedback** — it is harder to check whether instructions are being followed correctly

Minimising strategies:

- Use **multiple communication channels** — email, phone, written procedures — to reinforce instructions
 - Establish **clear reporting schedules** (e.g., daily or weekly check-ins)
 - Provide **written instructions and visual materials** that supervisors can refer to onsite without needing Louise
 - Create a **clear escalation procedure** so supervisors know who to contact and how when problems arise
 - Ask supervisors to **paraphrase instructions back** during phone briefings to confirm understanding
-

Q4. Louise will have to follow instructions from her own management and from the local council. What should she do to ensure she clearly understands these?

Louise should apply the strategies for **receiving and following instructions**:

- **Listen carefully** and concentrate fully during briefings
- **Avoid jumping to conclusions** — do not assume she knows what is meant before the instruction is complete
- **Paraphrase the instructions back** to her own management and the council to confirm her understanding
- **Ask questions** — both general (for the overview) and specific (for particular facts and standards)

- **Double-check any safety or compliance requirements** — especially important when dealing with a government department
 - **Ask for clarification in writing** where possible, so instructions are documented and cannot be distorted later
 - **Follow up** if something is unclear as implementation proceeds
-

◆ BUSINESS CASE STUDY: "WARMING TO THE SYSTEM" — Fully Solved

(Article by David Wood, Vice President, BHP Copper)

Q1. "People connect with people; and therein lies the cornerstone to success." What does the writer mean?

The writer means that no technology, system, or corporate structure creates real success on its own. It is the **human connections** — the relationships, shared purposes, and emotional bonds between people — that drive genuine organisational performance. When employees connect with each other and with the organisation's purpose, they are motivated, engaged, and productive. Without this human connectivity, even the best systems and strategies fall flat.

Q2. Why do most companies start out in business?

Most companies start out by **seeing and filling a need in the community**. Their original purpose is to continue to fulfil that need — not primarily to make a profit. The article uses the Walt Disney Corporation as an example: its core purpose is *"To bring happiness to millions"* — something people can emotionally connect with. Profit is a **by-product** of fulfilling that purpose well.

Q3. What limits a company's business success?

According to the article, a company's success is limited by **poor connectivity** — the failure to make meaningful emotional and purposeful connections with its employees. When companies define themselves only through profit-driven mission statements, they **fail to connect with employees** who are not motivated by shareholder wealth. The use of exclusive **scientific and economic language** further isolates management from staff, creating a disconnection that demoralises employees and limits performance.

Q4. How can managers and staff with good communication skills add to a company's success?

Managers and staff with good communication skills can:

- **Connect people to the organisation's real purpose** — helping employees see beyond profit to a greater cause they can believe in
 - **Use emotional language** alongside factual language, which resonates with all employees regardless of their technical background
 - **Create a positive communication climate** where people feel valued, heard, and motivated
 - **Reduce the disconnect** between senior management and staff by communicating in a **language common to all**, not only economic or scientific terms
 - **Improve motivation and performance** — as the article argues, people respond more to purpose than to profit, and good communicators can link daily work to that purpose
-

◆ KEY TERMS — Chapter 5 (Definitions for Your Exam)

Term	Definition
Direct instructions	Straight-to-the-point instructions that indicate who, what, when, where, and how a task should be completed
Workplace instructions	Instructions that explain objectives, provide background, and describe the intended outcome, leaving the receiver to decide how/when/where to achieve it
Routine instructions	Simple, standard instructions for regular, familiar tasks
Sequence	The logical order in which steps of an instruction are presented (simple to complex, familiar to unfamiliar, or required task order)
Visual materials	Graphics, symbols, diagrams, sketches, or pictures used alongside verbal instructions to add clarity and reinforce meaning
Oral report	A spoken account of what, where, when, who, and why something happened, using appropriate workplace language

◆ PREDICTIVE EXAM QUESTIONS — Chapter 5 (With Answers)

These are questions your professor is likely to construct from Chapter 5 content — beyond what the book directly asks.

PQ1. A new employee is given instructions on how to operate a piece of machinery. The supervisor simply tells them verbally once and walks away. Two hours later, the machine is used incorrectly and an accident occurs. Using the systematic approach from Chapter 5, explain what went wrong and what the supervisor should have done.

Answer: The supervisor violated almost every step of the 6-step systematic approach. They only completed Step 1 (explanation) and skipped Steps 2 through 6 entirely. They did not **demonstrate** the operation (Step 2), did not **review** the instructions (Step 3), did not ask the employee to **paraphrase back** (Step 4), did not **observe** the employee use the machine before leaving (Step 5), and did not create a **feedback loop** through questions and answers (Step 6). Additionally, they violated the guideline to **demonstrate the skills required** when a task involves machinery, and failed to **emphasise safety measures** in the introduction. The correct approach would have been to walk through all six systematic steps and ensure the employee was confirmed competent before operating the machinery unsupervised.

PQ2. Compare and contrast open and closed questions in the context of giving and receiving workplace instructions. Give an example of each.

Answer: An **open question** invites a full, explanatory response and is used when the instructor wants to assess the receiver's depth of understanding or gather more information. For example: *"Can you explain to me the full process of what you would do if a safety alarm went off during this task?"* This tells the instructor whether the receiver has genuinely understood the procedure.

A **closed question** requires a short, specific answer — typically yes/no or a single fact — and is used when the instructor needs to confirm a particular detail. For example: *"Is the safety switch turned off before you begin?"*

In giving instructions, both are valuable: open questions test comprehension; closed questions confirm specific facts. When receiving instructions, open questions help the receiver get a broader understanding, while closed questions pin down specific steps or requirements.

PQ3. Louise Lake from the Water Watchers case study needs to give the same set of instructions to three different audiences: university-trained environmental trainers, unskilled coastal work team members, and office accounting staff. How should she adapt her instructions for each group?

Answer: Louise must apply the guideline to **use words appropriate to the receiver's level of understanding** and **use familiar and simple words** for each group.

For the **environmental trainers**: she can use technical terminology related to coastal regeneration, discuss the academic and environmental principles behind the work, and focus on curriculum delivery and assessment procedures. They have high background knowledge.

For the **unskilled work team members**: she must use the simplest possible language, avoid all jargon, rely heavily on **visual materials, demonstrations, and step-by-step breakdowns**. Safety instructions must be especially clear and repeated in the conclusion. She should follow the full 6-step systematic approach and allow ample time for practice and questions.

For the **accounting staff**: language should be professional and procedural but focused specifically on financial processes — timesheet systems, wage procedures, material ordering. She should provide written procedures manuals as reference tools and use forms/diagrams to illustrate the workflow.

PQ4. Explain why oral reports are considered less reliable than written reports. What can a communicator do to minimise the weaknesses of an oral report?

Answer: The book identifies three weaknesses of oral reports: they are **informal**, meaning they may not be taken as seriously as written reports; they can become **distorted** as information is passed from person to person; and they are **easier to ignore** since there is no permanent document to refer back to.

To minimise these weaknesses, a communicator should: (1) structure the oral report clearly using the **5Ws (What, Where, When, Who, Why)** framework; (2) use **simple, direct language** with one idea per sentence to reduce the chance of misinterpretation; (3) follow up the oral report with a **written summary** where possible, especially for important matters; (4) use **"first," "second," "third"** to guide the listener through a clear sequence; and (5) invite **questions** after the report to clarify any points that may have been misunderstood.

PQ5. "A systematic approach to instructions is necessary." Do you agree? Justify your answer using the six steps of the systematic approach from Judith Dwyer's Chapter 5.

Answer: Yes, absolutely. A one-way instruction — simply telling someone what to do — assumes that hearing equals understanding, which is rarely true. The six-step systematic approach is necessary because it treats instruction as an **interactive, confirmed process**, not a one-way broadcast.

Step 1 (explanation) ensures the receiver has the information. Step 2 (demonstration) makes abstract instructions concrete and observable. Step 3 (review) reinforces and clarifies. Step 4 (paraphrasing by the receiver) is the critical confirmation step — it proves understanding in the receiver's own words, not just a nod. Step 5 (observation in the workplace) tests real-world application before errors become costly. Step 6 (two-way feedback) closes the loop and allows ongoing correction.

Without this system, as seen in workplaces where instructions fail, tasks are completed incorrectly, safety is compromised, and time is wasted on rework. The systematic approach protects both the organisation and the individual.

CHAPTER 2: THE SEVEN C's OF EFFECTIVE COMMUNICATION

Complete Exam Preparation Guide — Business Communication

WHAT THIS CHAPTER IS ABOUT (Big Picture)

This chapter is about the **seven principles** — called the **Seven C's** — that make any business message effective, whether written or spoken. Every business message you write or speak should be checked against these seven qualities. The chapter is extremely **practical and example-heavy**, and your professor will almost certainly ask you to:

- **Define** each C
- **Apply** each C to a real or given situation
- **Identify violations** (wordy vs. concise, insensitive vs. considerate, etc.)
- **Rewrite** poor examples using the correct C

Think of the Seven C's as a **quality checklist** for every professional message you ever send.

◆ THE OVERVIEW — All Seven C's at a Glance

#	C	One-Line Core Meaning
I	Completeness	Give all the information the reader needs
II	Conciseness	Say it in the fewest possible words
III	Consideration	Put the reader first; use "you" attitude
IV	Concreteness	Be specific, definite, and vivid
V	Clarity	Make the meaning clear and easy to understand
VI	Courtesy	Be respectful, tactful, and nondiscriminatory
VII	Correctness	Use right grammar, facts, and level of language

The book says: **all seven C's can apply to both oral and written communication.**

◆ C-I: COMPLETENESS

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

A business message is complete when it contains all the facts the reader or listener needs for the reaction you desire.

Communicators — senders and receivers both — are influenced by their **mental filters**: backgrounds, viewpoints, needs, experiences, attitudes, status, and emotions. Because of these differences, you must **assess your messages through the eyes of the receiver** to make sure all relevant information is included.

✅ Four Benefits of Complete Messages (The Book Lists These — Know All Four)

1. **More likely to bring desired results** without the expense of additional messages
 2. **Build goodwill** — they show concern for the receiver's needs
 3. **Prevent costly lawsuits** that may result when important information is missing
 4. **Seemingly inconsequential communications can be surprisingly important** if the information they contain is complete and effective
-

✓ Three Guidelines for Completeness (Checklist 2.1 — Memorize)

1. **Provide all necessary information**
 2. **Answer all questions asked**
 3. **Give something extra, when desirable**
-

♦ GUIDELINE 1: Provide All Necessary Information

When you initiate a message, check to make sure you have provided **all the information the reader needs** for thorough, accurate understanding.

The Five W's Method — one of the best ways to ensure completeness:

- **Who**
- **What**
- **When**
- **Where**
- **Why**
- (and also **How** — the "other essentials")

Practical Example from the Book:

- To **order merchandise**: state *what* you want, *when* you need it, to *whom* and *where* it is to be sent, and *how* payment will be made
 - To **reserve a hotel banquet room**: specify accommodations needed (what), location (where), sponsoring organization (who), date and time (when), event (why), and other necessary details (how)
-

♦ GUIDELINE 2: Answer All Questions Asked

Whenever you reply to an inquiry, **try to answer all questions — stated AND implied**.

The book warns: *"A colleague or prospective customer's reaction to an incomplete reply is likely to be unfavorable."* Why? Because the customer may think:

- The respondent is **careless**
- The respondent is **purposely trying to conceal a weak spot**
- Omissions **cast suspicions**

Key Rule: Look for questions — some may even appear **buried within a paragraph**. Locate them and answer precisely.

If you have **no information** on a particular question, say so clearly. If you have **unfavorable information**, handle your reply with **both tact and honesty**.

The Book's Example:

A software distributor replied to a dealer's letter answering only 4 of 7 questions — the original questions were unnumbered and buried in long paragraphs. The reply, incomplete and unfriendly, caused the distributor to **lose the business and goodwill** of a potential customer.

Tip from the Book: Sometimes before you can answer an inquiry, you need specific information from the inquirer. In that case, list the needed details on a **reply form** that the inquirer can fill out and return. This way both your answer and the respondent's will be complete.

♦ **GUIDELINE 3: Give Something Extra, When Desirable**

Sometimes you must do **more than answer the customer's specific questions** — their questions may be inadequate, or they may not know what they need.

Example from the Book (Rotary Club):

An out-of-town member writes: *"I'm new to the city and would like to consider joining your club. As I will be visiting your club within the month, will you please tell me where the next meeting will be held?"*

If you answered only this one question, your letter would be **incomplete**. You should also include:

- Directions to the building
- Parking facilities
- Day, date, and time of meeting
- Program for the next meeting

This is the **"something extra"** that the reader really needs and appreciates.

Book Principle: Use **good judgment** in offering additional material if the sender's message was incomplete. The reason for including something extra will usually be obvious; when it is not completely clear, **explain why** you are including the additional information.

✗ **Examples of Incomplete Questions (from the Book)**

Fax 1 — Incomplete question:

"Please fax me in return the departures from Singapore to Hong Kong on the 8th."

→ You would have to give something extra: times of day, airlines flying that route, costs, departure and arrival times.

Fax 2 — Incomplete question:

"How come my request for an interview letter did not receive a response?"

→ When was the letter sent? Who sent it? To whom was it sent? You need to seek these answers before responding.

Letter 1 (Incomplete) vs. Letter 1 (Revised Complete):

The incomplete letter to a new savings depositor merely thanks the customer and makes a vague offer of service. The revised complete letter specifically names services like passbook deposits (earning 6½% interest), Better-Than-Checking service, Mortgage Loans, Money Market Certificates, and Free Customer Parking — each described in specific, helpful detail.

Checklist 2.1 — Completeness (The Book's Own List)

1. Remember the **five W's**: Who? What? When? Where? Why?
 2. Answer **all questions**:
 - a. Stated questions from questioner
 - b. Implied questions from questioner
 3. Give **extra information** when desirable
-

◆ C-II: CONCISENESS

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

Conciseness is saying what you have to say in the fewest possible words without sacrificing the other C qualities. A concise message is complete without being wordy.

The book adds: *"Conciseness is a prerequisite to effective business communication."*

✅ Why Conciseness Matters (The Book's Reasons — Know All Five)

1. A concise message **saves time and expense** for both sender and receiver
 2. It **contributes to emphasis** — by eliminating unnecessary words, important ideas stand out
 3. Combined with a **you-view**, concise messages are inherently more interesting to recipients
 4. Concise messages show **respect for recipients** by not cluttering their professional lives with unnecessary information
 5. The principle: **"once is often enough"** (from the Communication Probe)
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✅ Three Guidelines for Conciseness

1. **Eliminate wordy expressions**
 2. **Include only relevant material**
 3. **Avoid unnecessary repetition**
-

◆ GUIDELINE 1: Eliminate Wordy Expressions

The book gives **7 specific suggestions** for reducing wordiness:

🖍 Suggestion 1: Use Single-Word Substitutes Instead of Phrases

Wordy

Concise

At this time

Now

Due to the fact that

Because

Have need for

Need

In due course

Soon

 Suggestion 2: Omit Trite, Unnecessary Expressions

Wordy

Please be advised that your admission statement was received

Allow me to say how helpful your response was

Concise

Your admission statement has been received

Your last response was helpful

 Suggestion 3: Replace Wordy Conventional Statements with Concise Versions

Wordy

Please find attached the list you requested

Such refreshing comments are few and far between

Concise

The list you requested is attached

Such refreshing comments are scarce

Book Note: *"Enclosed/Attached is the list requested"* is the concise standard form.

 Suggestion 4: Avoid Overusing Empty Phrases

Wordy

It was known by Mr. Smith that we must reduce inventory

There are four rules that should be observed

Concise

Mr. Smith knew we must reduce inventory

Four rules should be observed

Suggestion 5: Omit "Which" and "That" Clauses Whenever Possible

Wordy

Concise

She bought desks that are of the executive type She bought executive-type desks

The receipt that is enclosed documents your purchase The enclosed receipt documents your purchase

Suggestion 6: Eliminate Unnecessary Prepositional Phrases

Wordy

Concise

The issue of most relevance is teamwork The most relevant issue is teamwork

In most cases the date of the policy is indicated in the upper right corner The policy date is in the upper right corner

Suggestion 7: Limit Use of the Passive Voice

Wordy (Passive)

Concise (Active)

The total balance due will be found on page 2 of this report The balance due is on page 2 of this report

The reports are to be submitted by employees prior to 5:00, at which time they will be received by Mr. Jones Please submit your reports to Mr. Jones by 5:00

Important Book Warning: *"In all attempts to reduce wordiness, you must be careful to not distort meaning. Conciseness reflects the thoughtful elimination of unnecessary words."*

GUIDELINE 2: Include Only Relevant Material

The effective, concise message should omit not only unnecessarily wordy expressions but also **irrelevant statements**. To include only relevant facts, observe:

1. **Stick to the purpose of the message**
2. **Delete irrelevant words and rambling sentences**

3. **Omit information obvious to the receiver** — do not repeat at length what has already been told
4. **Avoid long introductions, unnecessary explanations, excessive adjectives and prepositions, pompous words, gushy politeness**
5. **Get to the important point tactfully and concisely**

Example from the Book:

Wordy: *"We hereby wish to let you know that our company is pleased with the confidence you have reposed in us."*

Concise: *"We appreciate your confidence."*

Wordy: *"At this time I am writing to you to enclose an interview card, which has been post-paid, for the purpose of arranging a convenient time when we might get together for a personal interview."*

Concise: *"Please return the enclosed interview card to set up a convenient time for an interview."*

♦ GUIDELINE 3: Avoid Unnecessary Repetition

The book says: *"Unnecessary repetition leads to dullness."* Sometimes repetition is necessary for **emphasis** — but when the same thing is said two or three times without reason, the message becomes **wordy and boring**.

Three ways to eliminate unnecessary repetition:

1. **Use a shorter name** after you have mentioned the long one once.
Instead of "North Central Company" again and again → use "North Central"
2. **Use pronouns or initials** rather than repeat long names.
Instead of "American Association of Technical Analysts" again and again → use "it" or "they" or "AATA"
Rule: When using well-known initials or acronyms, give the **full reference first with initials in parentheses**: *"The North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) is being debated in Congress."*
3. **Cut out all needless repetition of phrases and sentences.** Sometimes you can combine two or even more sentences using subordinate clauses or phrases.

Wordy (from the book):

"Will you ship us sometime, anytime during the month of October would be fine, or even November if you are rushed (November would suit us just as well, in fact a little bit better) 300 of the regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center. Thank you in advance for sending these along to us by parcel post, and not express, as press is too expensive."

Concise:

"Please ship parcel post, before the end of November, 300 regular 3- by 15-inch blue felt armbands with white sewn letters in the center."



Checklist 2.2 — Conciseness

1. Use one word in place of phrases; one sentence in place of two. Read out loud to "listen" for wordiness.
 2. Omit outdated trite expressions.
 3. Ask yourself: What material is really relevant?
 4. Look for unnecessary repetition: Does the same word or idea appear too often?
-

◆ C-III: CONSIDERATION

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

Consideration means preparing every message with the message receivers in mind; try to put yourself in their place.

When you are considerate:

- You **do not lose your temper**
- You **do not accuse** them without facts
- You **do not charge them** without facts
- You are aware of their **desires, problems, circumstances, emotions, and probable reactions** to your request
- You handle the matter from **their point of view**

The book also calls this: **"you-attitude," empathy, the human touch, and understanding of human nature.**

Broader meaning: Consideration underlies the **other six C's** of good business communication. You adapt your language and message content to your receiver's needs.

✅ Three Specific Ways to Show Consideration

1. **Focus on "you" instead of "I" and "we"**
 2. **Show audience benefit or interest in the receiver**
 3. **Emphasize positive, pleasant facts**
-

◆ WAY 1: Focus on "You" Instead of "I" or "We"

To create considerate, audience-oriented messages, focus on **how message receivers will benefit**, what they will receive, and what they want or need to know.

We-Attitude vs. You-Attitude Examples (from the Book):

We-Attitude

I am delighted to announce that we will be extending our hours to make shopping more convenient.

We're sure you must be frustrated by the length of time it has taken to ship your order for Polish gargoyles.

You-Attitude

You will be able to shop evenings with the extended hours.

The Polish gargoyles you ordered will reach you within a week.

⚠️ Important Caution from the Book:

Showing consideration involves **more than just using "you"** instead of "I" or "we." Messages that use "we" can be receiver-oriented if **"we" includes the recipient** of the message. On the other hand, messages that use "you" can be **insensitive in negative situations**.

In fact, **sometimes avoiding "you" can reduce potential defensiveness** or allow the receiver to save face.

Example — Insensitive vs. Considerate (from the Book):

Insensitive

You failed to enclose your check in the envelope.

Your contract tells you plainly that...

You are completely off base in your proposal.

Considerate

The check was not enclosed. [passive voice]

The envelope we received did not have a check in it.
[depersonalized]

I'm always happy to discuss the contract terms with new employees. [receiver as part of group]

We have differing interpretations of the utility of the proposal.
[sender-oriented with acceptance of responsibility]

The proposed plan has three aspects that need clarification.
[depersonalized]

♦ WAY 2: Show Audience Benefit or Interest in the Receiver

Whenever possible and true, **show how your receivers will benefit** from whatever the message asks or announces.

Benefits must:

- Meet **recipients' needs**
- Address **their concerns**
- Offer them **rewards**
- Most importantly — be **perceived as benefits by the receivers**

This means you must **identify the legitimate benefits** of your position, policy, or product, and then **put yourself in the place of the receivers** to assess their perspectives.

Book Principle: Receivers will be more likely to react favorably and do what you suggest if you **show that benefits are worth the effort and cost** you ask of them. In situations where actual direct benefit is impossible or irrelevant to the subject matter, the message should at least show **interest in and concern for the recipient's needs or viewpoints**.

Important Warning: Merely inserting the word "you" does **not** ensure you-attitude. Example — *"You will be glad to know that we now have a walk-up window open 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. every weekday."* — Some readers wonder, *"So what?"*

Revised with real reader benefit: *"You can now take care of your banking needs at our new Walk-Up Window. It is open with a capable teller to serve you 7–9 A.M. and 3–8 P.M. Monday through Friday."*

Reader-benefit appeals are desirable for:

- Job application letters
- Favor requests
- Announcements to customers, prospective buyers, stockholders, and employees
- Whether writing to one person or large numbers

♦ **WAY 3: Emphasize Positive, Pleasant Facts**

A third way to show consideration is to **accent the positive** — stress what **can** be done instead of what **cannot** be done, and focus on words your recipient can consider favorably.

Negative vs. Positive Examples (from the Book):

Negative — Unpleasant	Positive — Pleasant
<i>It is impossible to open an account for you today.</i>	<i>As soon as your signature card reaches us, we will gladly open an account.</i>
<i>We don't refund if the returned item is soiled and unsalable.</i>	<i>We refund when the returned item is clean and resalable.</i>
<i>When you travel on company expense, you will not receive approval for first-class fare.</i>	<i>When you travel on company expense, your approved fare is for tourist class.</i>

Positive words people react to favorably: *benefit, cordial, happy, help, generous, loyal, pleasure, thanks, thoughtful.*

Negative words that arouse unfavorable reactions: *blame, complaint, failed, fault, negligence, regret, reject, trouble, unfair.*

Example from the Book (Bad opening):

"We regret that, since you closed your account, your name will be missing from our long list of satisfied customers. We sincerely hope that, despite the best efforts of our fine staff, there were no occasions on which you felt we failed to serve you properly."

This is bad because the underlined negative words (regret, closed, missing, failed) focus on ideas you'd rather the reader NOT think about.

Book Note: True consideration is a result of **integrity and ethics in communication.**

 Checklist 2.3 — Consideration

1. See your material from your reader's point of view.
2. "You" is more desirable than "I" or "we" in most instances.
3. Readers like to see benefits. Be sure benefits are a prominent part of the message.
4. Consciously use positive words; readers will react more favorably.

◆ C-IV: CONCRETENESS

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

Communicating concretely means being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general. It means using denotative (direct, explicit, often dictionary-based) rather than connotative words (ideas or notions suggested by or associated with a word or phrase).

Example from the Book:

The term *female* may appear in a personnel folder as part of a job description, yet widely different connotations may occur when using terms like *wife*, *mother*, *spinster*, *widow*, *maiden*, *matron*, or *dowager*. Each refers to *female* but with wide-ranging associations.

✅ Three Guidelines for Concreteness

1. Use specific facts and figures
 2. Put action in your verbs
 3. Choose vivid, image-building words
-

◆ GUIDELINE 1: Use Specific Facts and Figures

Whenever possible, use an **exact, precise statement or figure** in place of a general word to make your message more concrete.

Vague vs. Concrete Examples (from the Book):

Vague, General, Indefinite	Concrete, Precise
<i>Student GMAT scores are higher.</i>	<i>In 1996 the GMAT scores averaged 600; by 1997 they had risen to 610.</i>
<i>Eastern Europe is making progress in obtaining investments.</i>	<i>In 1990 investments in Eastern Europe were about US \$30 million; today that figure has increased by 12%.</i>
<i>She's a brain.</i>	<i>Her grade-point average in 1996 was 3.9 on a four-point scale.</i>

Vague words that lead to uncertainty (from the Book):

slightly, most, soon, high, almost, small, a few, slow, very, about, several

Three Exceptions to the "Facts and Figures" Rule:

The book notes that it is permissible — even desirable — to use general expressions in three cases:

1. When it is **not possible to be specific** — "You may not have the precise figures or facts."
2. When you **wish to be diplomatic (considerate)** — "You have missed three invitations" is harsh; "I've sent you several reminders" is more tactful.
3. When **exact figures are unimportant** — as in "more than half the committee was present."

♦ GUIDELINE 2: Put Action in Your Verbs

Verbs can activate other words and help make your sentences alive, more vigorous.

To have **dynamic sentences**: (1) use **active rather than passive verbs** and (2) put **action in your verbs** rather than in nouns and infinitives.

✔ Use the Active Voice

When the subject performs the action → verb is in the **active voice**.

When the subject receives the action → verb is in the **passive voice**.

Three Characteristics of a Passive Verb:

1. The subject does **not** do the acting in the sentence
2. The verb consists of **two or more words**, one of which is some form of "to be" (is, was, were, will be, has been, had been, or have been)
3. The word **"by"** is expressed or implied

Passive vs. Active Examples (from the Book):

Passive

The tests were administered by the professors.

Grades of students will be sent to you by the school.

Active

Professors administered the tests.

The school will send students their grades.

Four Reasons Active Verbs Are Better:

1. **Specific** — "The dean decided" is more explicit than "A decision has been made."
2. **Personal** — "You will note" is both personal and specific; "It will be noted" is impersonal.
3. **Concise** — The passive requires more words and thus slows both writing and reading.
4. **Emphatic** — Passive verbs dull action. Compare "The students held a contest" with "A contest was held by the students."

Three Situations Where Passive Voice Is Preferred:

1. When you want to **avoid personal, blunt accusations or comments** — "The October check was not included" is more tactful than "You failed to include..."
 2. When you want to **stress the object of the action** — "Your savings account is insured up to \$100,000" intentionally stresses "your account"
 3. When **the doer isn't important in the sentence** — "Three announcements were made before the meeting started" emphasizes the announcements, not who made them
-

✔ Put Action in Verbs, Not in Nouns

Seven verbs — *be, give, have, hold, make, put, and take* — (in any tense) are called "**deadly**" when the action they introduce is hidden in a "quiet" noun. Move the action from noun to verb.

Action Hiding in a "Quiet" Noun → Action in the Verb:

Noun-heavy

The function of this office is the collection of payments and the compilation of statements.

Professor H. will give consideration to the report.

The proposal has a requirement for...

Students held the meeting in the office.

Verb-strong

This office collects payments and compiles statements.

Professor H. will consider the report.

The proposal requires that...

Students met in the office.

✓ Put Action in Verbs, Not in Infinitives

Action Hiding in Infinitive

The duty of a secretary is to check all incoming mail and to record it. In addition, it is his or her responsibility to keep the assignment book up to date.

Action in the Verb

A secretary checks and records all incoming mail and keeps the assignment book up to date.

◆ GUIDELINE 3: Choose Vivid, Image-Building Words

Among the devices you can use to make your messages **forceful, vivid, and specific** are:

- **Sensory appeals**
- **Comparisons**
- **Figurative language**
- **Concrete nouns**
- **Well-chosen adjectives and adverbs**

The book cautions: use these devices with caution; business writing uses fewer descriptors than magazine articles or fiction.

✓ Sensory Appeal

Concrete language often evokes a **sensory response** (appealing to one or more of the five senses).

Instead of: *"It was hot in the factory"*

→ *"Sweat trickled down the arms of the line workers"* (sight and touch)

→ *"The secretary's face was wrinkled after squinting into the computer the entire day"* (sight)

✔ Comparisons (Analogies)

Analogies can make an unclear idea clear or make an idea more vivid.

Bland Image

Proposals submitted this quarter were uninteresting.

This is a long letter.

More Vivid Image

Too many simple sentences, too many simplistic ideas gave the impression of the writing of a first-year student.

This letter is three times as long as you said it would be.

✔ Figurative Language

Use figures of speech **sparingly** — they make an idea more vivid but business writing uses them cautiously.

Literal (and Dull)

Her work in groups was exemplary.

Some women were stopped in their promotions.

Our budget analysis will begin soon.

More Vivid, Figurative

She could be called "the spark plug of the group."

Many women faced the "glass ceiling" in their company.

This is the first shot across your bow as we begin to review your budget for next year.

📋 Checklist 2.4 — Concreteness

1. Were you precise in using facts and figures wherever possible?
 2. Did you use the active voice more than the passive?
 3. Is there action in verbs rather than in nouns or infinitives?
 4. Did you try to occasionally use vivid, image-building words? But in business writing, use them sparingly.
-

◆ C-V: CLARITY

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

Getting the meaning from your head into the head of your reader — accurately — is the purpose of clarity.

We all carry around our own unique interpretations, ideas, and experiences associated with words. Clarity ensures the message is received exactly as intended.

✅ Two Guidelines for Clarity

1. **Choose precise, concrete, and familiar words**
 2. **Construct effective sentences and paragraphs**
-

◆ GUIDELINE 1: Choose Precise, Concrete, and Familiar Words

Clarity is achieved through a **balance between precise language and familiar language**.

- **Precise language** = select exactly the right word to convey your meaning
- **Familiar language** = select a word that is part of your personal repertoire, familiar to the audience, and appropriate for the situation

Rule: When you have a choice between a **long word and a short one**, use the **short, familiar word** that your reader or listener will quickly understand.

Also, use **synonyms instead of Latin terms** if they are unfamiliar to your audience.

Familiar vs. Pretentious Words (from the Book):

Familiar	Pretentious
about	circa (L)
after	subsequent
home	domicile
for example	e.g. (L)
pay	remuneration
invoice	statement for payment

Unfamiliar vs. Familiar Example:

Unfamiliar: "After our perusal of pertinent data, the conclusion is that a lucrative market exists for the subject property."

Familiar: "The data we studied show that your property is profitable and in high demand."

The Book's Classic Story (The Plumber):

A plumber wrote to the National Bureau of Standards saying hydrochloric acid is good for cleaning out clogged drains. A technical specialist replied with jargon: *"The efficacy of hydrochloric acid is indisputable, but the corrosive residue is incompatible with metallic permanence."* The plumber thanked them for agreeing with him — when of course the bureau was disagreeing! Finally the department manager wrote simply: *"Don't use hydrochloric acid. It eats hell out of the pipes."* This story perfectly illustrates why **familiar language beats jargon** for clarity.

Book Rule: Although it is appropriate to use technical terms and business jargon in some professional situations, avoid it when you communicate with a person who is **not acquainted with the terminology**. If you must use such terms, **define them briefly and clearly**.

♦ GUIDELINE 2: Construct Effective Sentences and Paragraphs

At the core of clarity is the **sentence**. Important characteristics to consider are: **length, unity, coherence, and emphasis**.

✓ LENGTH

Generally, **short sentences are preferred**. The suggested average sentence length is **17 to 20 words**. Because variety in sentence length adds interest, adopt a range of from 3 to 30 or more words. But:

- If a sentence exceeds **40 words**, try to rewrite it into more than one sentence
 - If **all sentences are short** (under 10 words), the result is **primer-like language** — choppy and overly simple
-

✓ UNITY

In a sentence — whether simple, compound, or complex — unity means that you have **one main idea**, and any other ideas in the sentence must be **closely related** to it.

"I like Jim, and the Eiffel Tower is in Paris" — obviously NOT a unified sentence because the two ideas are unrelated.

✓ COHERENCE

In a coherent sentence, words are **correctly arranged** so that ideas clearly express the intended meaning. Place the **correct modifier as close as possible** to the word it is supposed to modify.

Unclear vs. Clear Examples (from the Book):

Unclear

Being an excellent lawyer, I am sure you can help us.

His report was about managers, broken down by age and gender.

After planting 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into our botanist's farm and crushed them.

Clear

Being an excellent lawyer, you can surely help us. OR As you are an excellent lawyer, I am sure you...

His report focused on age and gender of managers.

After our botanist had planted 10,000 berry plants, the deer came into his farm and crushed them.

✓ EMPHASIS

Emphasis is the quality that gives **force to important parts** of sentences and paragraphs. Writers must decide what needs emphasis, and then choose correct sentence structure.

Rule: In a complex sentence, the **main idea should be placed in the main clause**; the less important points are in subordinate (dependent) clauses or phrases.

Little Emphasis vs. Better Emphasis (from the Book):

Little Emphasis

The airplane finally approached the speed of sound, and it became very difficult to control.

Candidates should be motivated and have interest in static and dynamic testing of material, and have those prerequisites and others.

Better Emphasis

As it finally approached the speed of sound, the airplane became very difficult to control.

Prerequisites in candidates should include expertise in static and dynamic testing of material.

Visual emphasis methods (from the Book): headings, tabulations, itemizations, graphs, line charts, pie charts, underlinings, italics, indentations, colored capitals or italics, or even wide or short margins.



Checklist 2.5 — Clarity

1. Choose as precise or as concrete a word as possible.
2. Select words that have a high sense of appropriateness for the reader.

3. Opt for the familiar word, the one that is not pretentious.
 4. Limit average sentence length to 17 to 20 words.
 5. Insert no more than one main idea into a sentence.
 6. Arrange words so that the main idea occurs early in a sentence.
-

◆ C-VI: COURTESY

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

True courtesy involves being aware not only of the perspective of others, but also their feelings. Courtesy stems from a sincere you-attitude. It is not merely politeness with mechanical insertions of "please" and "thank you," although applying socially accepted manners is a form of courtesy. Rather, it is politeness that grows out of respect and concern for others.

Knowing your audience allows you to use statements of courtesy; be aware of your message receiver.

✅ Three Guidelines for Courtesy

1. **Be sincerely tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative**
 2. **Use expressions that show respect**
 3. **Choose nondiscriminatory expressions**
-

◆ GUIDELINE 1: Be Sincerely Tactful, Thoughtful, and Appreciative

Tact

Though few people are intentionally abrupt or blunt, these **negative traits** are a common cause of discourtesy. They stem from:

- A mistaken idea of conciseness
- Negative personal attitudes
- Not knowing the culture of a country or even groups of people

Tactless/Blunt vs. More Tactful Examples (from the Book):

Tactless, Blunt

More Tactful

Stupid letter; I can't understand any of it.

It's my understanding...

Clearly, you did not read my latest fax.

Sometimes my wording is not precise; let me try again.

I rewrote that letter three times; the point was clear.

I'm sorry the point was not clear; here is another version.

Book Note: Writing a letter to a customer outside the company requires more "niceties" than writing an email within your company. A one-sentence internal email to a colleague could be short:

"Phil, give me a call at #41279 and give me the number of the report you're sending along to the VP."

But a fax or letter to a foreign company would not be as short or blunt; instead, add a few more tactful words.

Thoughtfulness and Appreciation

Writers who send cordial, courteous messages of **deserved congratulations and appreciation** (to persons both inside and outside the firm) help **build goodwill**. The value of goodwill or public esteem for the firm may be worth thousands (or millions) of dollars.

Book Tip: Be especially thoughtful and courteous when communicating with **Asian cultures** — they like the soft, more polite approach in both oral and written communication.

♦ GUIDELINE 2: Use Expressions That Show Respect

No reader wants to receive messages that offend. The book covers two types of expressions to avoid:

Omit Irritating Expressions

The book provides a **consensus list** of expressions many people find irritating (particularly when used with "you" or "your"). Avoid ALL of these:

contrary to your inference, delinquency (delinquent), I do not agree with you, if you care, I'm sure you must realize, inexcusable, irresponsible, obnoxious, obviously you overlooked, owing to your questionable credit we are unable to, simply nonsense, surely you don't expect, we are amazed you can't, we don't believe, we expect you to, we find it difficult to believe that, we must insist, we take issue, why have you ignored, you are delinquent, you are probably ignorant of the fact that, you claim that, you did not tell us, you failed to, you forgot to, you have to, you leave us no choice, you neglected to (overlooked), you say, you should know, you surely don't expect, your apparent disregard of our previous request leaves us no alternative, your complaint, your failure to, your insinuation, your neglect, your stubborn silence.

Omit Questionable Humor

"Laughter to one person is disgust for another; each of us has a different sense of humor." A flippant attitude can be in **poor taste**.

Book Rule: When in doubt as to the relevance of the humor, **leave it out**. When in doubt, be more formal.

Note 1 (Offensive): *"Hey man, what's this I hear about the good news? You sure pulled a fast one this past weekend — and then didn't tell any of us about it. Give my regards to the little lady. And wish her the best; she'll need it."*

Note 2 (More Courteous): *"Warm congratulations on your wedding! Well, you certainly took us by surprise... we — my wife and I — wish you the best. Give our warm regards to your new partner."*

♦ GUIDELINE 3: Choose Nondiscriminatory Expressions

Another requirement for courtesy is the use of **nondiscriminatory language** that reflects equal treatment of people regardless of:

- Gender
- Race
- Ethnic origin

- Physical features
-

✔ Sexist Terms: "Man" Words

For a long period, *man* was accepted to denote humanity at large. Today many people connect *man* with a "male human being." English uses **alternative expressions** that are **neuter in form**:

Questionable	More Desirable
freshman	entering students; first-year students
manpower	workers; employees; work force; personnel
man-made	manufactured; constructed; built
the best man for the position	the best person; the best candidate for the position

✔ Singular Pronouns

English lacks a neuter singular pronoun signifying "he" or "she." The trend today is to **avoid using *he*, *him*, and *his*** when referring to a hypothetical person or humanity in general.

Solutions (from the Book):

Questionable	More Desirable
<i>Anyone who comes to class late will get his grade reduced.</i>	<i>Students who come late to class will have their class grade reduced.</i> [Reworded to omit unnecessary pronouns]
<i>Each customer will have the new changes noted on his bill.</i>	<i>Customers will have the new changes noted on their bills.</i> [Reworded into the plural]
<i>"Our criteria are firm: he is to be a scholar; he is to be a good teacher."</i>	<i>Our criteria suggest he or she is to be a good scholar and a good teacher.</i> [Reworded to include both genders]

<i>"You guys should all be concerned about the issue."</i>	<i>Both men and women, all of you should be concerned about the issue.</i> [Reworded to include both genders]
<i>The executives may benefit from the stock options. He will...</i>	<i>The executives may benefit from the stock options. Each executive may...</i> [Reworded to repeat the noun]
<i>Each manager has an assigned parking place. He should park his car...</i>	<i>Every manager has been assigned a parking place. Each car should be parked in...</i> [Reworded into the passive]

Book Note: *"In sum, use good judgment. Some companies use the masculine he quite freely; know the culture of the company before making a final decision when writing."*

 Names

When using names, **treat each gender with respect: use names in parallel form.**

Undesirable	More Desirable
Ted Aprill and Ruth	Ted and Ruth Aprill
Mrs. Aprill and Ted	Ms. Aprill [if she desires this] and Mr. Aprill

 Checklist 2.6 — Courtesy

1. Ask yourself: Does the communication have a sincere you-attitude?
 2. Have someone else look at your statement if you have doubts about whether it is tactful. Another opinion may cause you to reconsider making a statement.
 3. Be cautious in using humor in communication. Here too it pays to have someone else review your words.
 4. Be careful in using discriminatory language; this means being aware of gender, race, age, color, creed, sexual preferences, or ethnic origins.
-

◆ C-VII: CORRECTNESS

📖 Core Definition (Must Memorize)

At the core of correctness is proper grammar, punctuation, and spelling.

However, the book expands this: a message may be **perfect grammatically and mechanically but still insult or lose a customer**. Therefore, correctness as applied to business messages also means the following **three characteristics**:

- 1. Use the right level of language
- 2. Check accuracy of figures, facts, and words
- 3. Maintain acceptable writing mechanics

◆ CHARACTERISTIC 1: Use the Right Level of Language

The book identifies **three levels of language**:

Level	Description
Formal	Often associated with scholarly writing — doctoral dissertations, scholarly articles, legal documents, top-level government agreements. Style is unconversational , usually impersonal , and often contains long and involved sentences .
Informal	More characteristic of business writing . Uses words that are short, well-known, and conversational . This is the level you should aim for in most business communication.
Substandard	Using incorrect words, incorrect grammar, faulty pronunciation — all suggest an inability to use good English . Avoid entirely.

More Formal vs. Less Formal (from the Book):

More Formal	Less Formal
participate	join
procure	get
endeavor	try

ascertain	find out
deem	think (believe)
edifice	building
utilize	use
interrogate	question

Substandard vs. More Acceptable (from the Book):

Substandard	More Acceptable
ain't	isn't, aren't
can't hardly	can hardly
aim at proving	aim to prove
irregardless	regardless
stoled	stolen
brung	brought
should of	should have

♦ **CHARACTERISTIC 2: Check Accuracy of Figures, Facts, and Words**

"It is impossible to convey meaning precisely, through words, from the head of the sender to a receiver. Our goal is to be as precise as possible."

This means **checking and double-checking** to ensure figures, facts, and words are correct.

For Figures and Facts, the Book says:

- **Verify your statistical data**
 - **Double-check your totals**
 - **Avoid guessing at laws** that have an impact on you, the sender, and your message receiver
 - **Have someone else read your message** if the topic involves data
 - **Determine whether a "fact" has changed over time**
-

✔ **Words That Confuse — The Book's List (Highly Examinable)**

The book gives a list of commonly confused words — these appear directly in the exercises. Know all of them:

Word Pair	Correct Meaning
a, an	Use <i>a</i> before consonant sounds or a long "u" sound. Use <i>an</i> before vowels or a silent "h."
accept, except	<i>Accept</i> is a verb meaning to receive. <i>Except</i> is a verb or preposition relating to omitting or leaving out.
anxious, eager	<i>Anxious</i> implies worry; <i>eager</i> conveys keen desire.
between, among	<i>Between</i> involves two people or two groups; <i>among</i> three or more.
biannually, biennially	<i>Biannually</i> means "two times a year" or "every 2 years"; <i>biennially</i> , "every 2 years."
continual, continuous	<i>Continual</i> means "recurring regularly" (like lapping ocean waves). <i>Continuous</i> means "without stopping."
counsel, council	<i>Counsel</i> means (as a verb) "to advise" and (as a noun) "lawyer" or "advice." <i>Council</i> (noun) is an advisory or governing group.
effect, affect	In business usage, <i>effect</i> is a noun meaning "result," "condition," or "influence." Both words are verbs — to <i>effect</i> is "to bring about"; to <i>affect</i> is "to influence."
eminent, imminent	<i>Eminent</i> means "high in station, merit, esteem," "prominent." <i>Imminent</i> means "about to happen," "threatening."

farther, further	<i>Farther</i> is more used to express distance in space; <i>further</i> for distance in time, quality, or degree.
imply, infer	<i>Imply</i> means "to insinuate" or "suggest"; <i>infer</i> means "to conclude." A writer implies; the reader infers.
principal, principle	<i>Principal</i> as an adjective means "chief," "main"; as a noun, "sum of money" or "head of a school." <i>Principle</i> means "rule" or "basic truth."
which, that, who	<i>That</i> refers to persons or things; <i>who</i> , to people; <i>which</i> , only to things.
who, whom	Use <i>who</i> as the subject of a verb — "Who will win?" Use <i>whom</i> as the object of a verb or a preposition — "Whom can you trust?"

♦ CHARACTERISTIC 3: Maintain Acceptable Writing Mechanics

All material relating to mechanics, word processing, and appearance of business messages is relevant. With computer grammar-checks and spell-checks, editing has become easier. Yet the book recommends **careful attention to the mechanical part** of every well-written document.

Checklist 2.7 — Correctness

1. Select the right level of language for your communication: either formal or informal.
2. Realize that informal language is most often used in business communication.
3. Check — often by letting another person read your material — for correct figures, facts, and words.
4. Apply the principles of accepted mechanics to your writing.

◆ EXERCISES AND PROBLEMS — Solved

Exercise 4: Restatement of Long Thoughts into Shorter Thoughts

Translate the gobbledygook into original proverbs:

a. "All's well that is finalized effectively."
→ **All's well that ends well.**

b. "Be it a minimal dwelling in a depressed socioeconomic area, there is no place like home."
→ **There's no place like home.**

c. "All programmed activity and nonutilization of recreational outlets make Jack a less than fully realized personality."
→ **All work and no play makes Jack a dull boy.**

d. "Do not attempt statistical estimates of your chickens before it is feasible to correlate volume variances with projected expectations."

→ **Don't count your chickens before they hatch.**

e. "The utilization of a superfluity of culinary personnel maximizes disorganization and has a deleterious effect on the broth."

→ **Too many cooks spoil the broth.**

Exercise 5: Formal to Informal Rewriting

The committee memo using formal, complex language should be rewritten in simple, informal business style. Key transformations:

- "respectfully request, indeed implore" → "we ask"
 - "earnestly seek your recommendation for criteria" → "please send us your suggestions"
 - "hallowed halls of academia" → "universities"
 - "It is the intent of the committee that you use all means available" → "Please use all available methods"
 - "submit no later than the 4th of October 199-" → "by October 4"
 - "be it known that your information be made available to the committee in both hard-copy form and computer disk, the latter compatible with MS-DOS machines" → "please send both a printed copy and an MS-DOS disk"
-

Exercise 6: Exercises on Choice of Words (Solved)

a. This act will not (**affect**) my confidence in you.

(*affect = to influence; effect would be a noun*)

b. I am (**eager**) to (**advise**) you that you are right.

(*eager = keen desire, not anxiety; advise = to give advice*)

c. (**Continual**) rains are drenching the fields.

(*continual = recurring regularly; continuous = without stopping*)

d. We assure you (**it's**) a pleasure to do as you suggest.

(*it's = it is; its = possessive*)

e. Enclosed (**is**) my check for (**\$100**).

(*"Enclosed is" is the correct concise form*)

f. RXZ College employs 10 (**eminent**) scholars.

(*eminent = prominent; imminent = about to happen*)

g. The dissension (**among**) the five departments has been settled by a (**well-known**) authority.

(*among = three or more; well-known is hyphenated as a modifier*)

h. The man (**who**) was crossing the street was struck by a car (**that**) Mr. Smith was driving.

(*who = person; that = thing*)

i. (**A**) university regent held (**a**) one-hour meeting with (**an**) honor society (**counsel**... actually **council** — governing group).

(*A before consonant sound; an before vowel/silent h; council = governing group*)

j. We sold (**fewer**) fans last month.

(*fewer = countable items; less = uncountable amounts*)

- k. We had (**already**) received the suit when your letter arrived. I am (**all ready**) to write this customer.
(*already = previously; all ready = completely prepared*)
- l. Your rug should (**lie**) (**smoothly**) on the floor.
(*lie = to rest; smoothly = adverb modifying the verb*)
- m. The (**principle**) of honesty should be evident here.
(*principle = rule or basic truth*)
- n. Be courteous to (**whoever**) comes to your desk.
(*whoever = subject of the verb "comes"*)
- o. A large number of bills (**are**) outstanding.
(*number of = plural subject*)
- p. Do you know (**whom**) the manager promoted yesterday?
(*whom = object of "promoted"*)
- q. The decision is a secret between Ron and (**me**).
(*me = object of preposition "between"*)
- r. We have a large (**number**) of suits here.
(*number = countable items*)
- s. Either Ellen or (**I**) will call you Monday.
(*I = subject of the verb "will call"*)
-

◆ KEY TERMS — Chapter 2 (Definitions for Your Exam)

Term	Definition
Seven C's	Seven principles of effective business communication: Completeness, Conciseness, Consideration, Concreteness, Clarity, Courtesy, Correctness
Completeness	A message containing all facts the reader or listener needs for the desired reaction
Conciseness	Saying what needs to be said in the fewest possible words without sacrificing other C qualities
Consideration	Preparing messages with the receiver in mind; the "you-attitude"
You-attitude	Focusing on how message receivers will benefit, what they will receive, and what they want to know

Concreteness	Being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general
Denotative words	Direct, explicit, dictionary-based meanings of words
Connotative words	Ideas or notions suggested by or associated with a word or phrase
Active voice	Sentence structure where the subject performs the action
Passive voice	Sentence structure where the subject receives the action
Clarity	Getting meaning from the head of the writer accurately into the head of the reader
Unity	One main idea per sentence, with all other ideas closely related to it
Coherence	Words correctly arranged so ideas clearly express the intended meaning
Emphasis	The quality that gives force to important parts of sentences and paragraphs
Courtesy	Politeness that grows out of respect and concern for others; a sincere you-attitude
Tact	Avoiding blunt or abrupt expressions; rephrasing to be respectful
Correctness	Using proper grammar, punctuation, spelling, right level of language, and accurate facts
Formal language	Unconversational, impersonal style used in scholarly/legal documents
Informal language	Short, well-known, conversational words; the standard for business writing

Substandard language	Incorrect words, grammar, or pronunciation that suggest inability to use good English
Tautology	Using two or more words to express a simple and single thought; wordiness
Five W's	Who, What, When, Where, Why — used to ensure completeness

◆ CHAPTER SUMMARY (The Book's Own — Internalize This)

- Be **complete** in giving your message receiver all necessary information. One way to remember this is to think of the five W's: who, what, when, where, and why.
 - Apply **conciseness** through eliminating wordy expressions, including only relevant material, and avoiding unnecessary repetition. Consistently ask: Which word, sentence, or paragraph may be eliminated without omitting relevant material?
 - Prepare your messages with the audience in mind. **Consideration** means putting yourself in their place. Focus on "you" in place of "I" or "we." Stress the positive in your messages.
 - Insert specific, definite, and vivid words to make your messages **concrete** — use specific facts and figures; put action in your verbs; and choose vivid, image-building words.
 - Think of **clarity** as using words familiar to the message receiver. Use sentences that average 17 to 20 words, contain one main idea, are coherent, and give emphasis to ideas more often in the beginning of a sentence.
 - Respect your message receiver. **Courtesy** means being tactful, thoughtful, and appreciative. Such writing also implies using expressions that show respect and using nondiscriminatory language.
 - Review all your communication for **correctness**. This last C focuses on correctness in grammar, punctuation, and spelling. Give thought to the right level of language and the checking of figures, facts, and words.
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◆ PREDICTIVE EXAM QUESTIONS — Chapter 2 (With Full Answers)

PQ1. Define all Seven C's of effective communication in one clear sentence each, and explain which one you consider the FOUNDATION of all others. Justify your answer.

Answer:

1. **Completeness** — A message is complete when it contains all the facts the reader needs for the desired reaction.
2. **Conciseness** — Conciseness means saying what needs to be said in the fewest possible words without sacrificing quality.
3. **Consideration** — Consideration means preparing every message with the receiver in mind, using the "you-attitude."
4. **Concreteness** — Concreteness means being specific, definite, and vivid rather than vague and general.
5. **Clarity** — Clarity means getting the meaning from the writer's head into the reader's head accurately.
6. **Courtesy** — Courtesy is politeness that grows out of genuine respect and concern for others, not just mechanical "please" and "thank you."
7. **Correctness** — Correctness means using proper grammar, right level of language, and accurate figures, facts, and words.

Foundation: Consideration is the foundation. The book states: *"In a broad but true sense, consideration underlies the other six C's of good business communication."* Every other C requires you to think about your receiver — how complete the message should be for them, how concise they need it, how concrete, how clear, how courteous, and at what level of correctness. Without consideration, the other six C's lose their purpose.

PQ2. A manager writes the following email to a client: "We are writing to advise you of the fact that due to the circumstances that have arisen pertaining to the matter of your order, it has been deemed appropriate by our organization to inform you that there will be a delay." Rewrite this using Conciseness principles, and identify the specific conciseness violations.

Answer:

Violations identified:

- "We are writing to advise you of the fact that" → trite expression, omit entirely
- "due to the circumstances that have arisen pertaining to the matter of" → wordy prepositional phrase
- "it has been deemed appropriate by our organization to inform you" → passive voice, empty phrase
- The entire sentence is passive, impersonal, and filled with empty phrases

Concise rewrite:

"Your order will be delayed. We apologize for the inconvenience and will update you with a new delivery date shortly."

This replaces 50+ words with 2 direct, active sentences that say the same thing clearly.

PQ3. Explain the difference between "you-attitude" and simply using the word "you." Give two examples where using "you" is actually inconsiderate.

Answer:

The "you-attitude" is about genuinely focusing on the **receiver's needs, benefits, and point of view** — not just grammatically inserting the word "you." Simply using "you" does not guarantee consideration.

Two examples where "you" is actually inconsiderate:

1. **In negative situations:** *"You failed to enclose your check in the envelope"* — using "you" here is accusatory and blunt. The considerate version removes "you": *"The check was not enclosed"* (passive voice, depersonalized).
2. **When it makes an accusation:** *"You are completely off base in your proposal"* — using "you" here is insulting. The considerate version is: *"We have differing interpretations of the utility of the proposal"* (sender-oriented, accepting shared responsibility).

In both cases, **removing or depersonalizing "you" is more considerate** than using it directly.

PQ4. What is the difference between the active voice and passive voice? Give three situations where the passive voice is PREFERRED over the active voice. Give an example for each.

Answer:

Active voice: The subject performs the action. It is direct, personal, concise, and emphatic.

Passive voice: The subject receives the action. It requires more words and can dull the action.

Three situations where passive is preferred:

1. **To avoid personal, blunt accusations:**
Active (blunt): *"You failed to include the October check."*
Passive (tactful): *"The October check was not included."*
 2. **To stress the object of the action:**
Active: *"We invite you."*
Passive (stresses receiver): *"You are invited."*
 3. **When the doer isn't important:**
Active: *"The committee made three announcements before the meeting started."*
Passive (emphasizes announcements): *"Three announcements were made before the meeting started."*
-

PQ5. Distinguish between "formal," "informal," and "substandard" language. Which level is most appropriate for business writing, and why?

Answer:

Formal language is associated with scholarly writing — doctoral dissertations, legal documents, top-level government agreements. It is unconversational, usually impersonal, and contains long and involved sentences. Example words: *participate, procure, endeavor, ascertain*.

Informal language is more characteristic of business writing. It uses words that are short, well-known, and conversational. Example words: *join, get, try, find out*. This is the standard for business emails, letters, and reports.

Substandard language uses incorrect words, incorrect grammar, or faulty pronunciation — suggesting an inability to use good English. Examples: *ain't, irregardless, brung, should of*.

Informal language is most appropriate for business writing because it is immediately understood by the widest range of readers, it saves time, it feels more personal and respectful, and it avoids the pretentious distance of formal language. The book specifically states: *"Informal writing is more characteristic of business writing — even more so if that writing occurs in an email message."*

PQ6. List and explain the seven suggestions for eliminating wordy expressions (Conciseness). Give one original example of your own for each.

Answer:

1. **Use single-word substitutes** — Replace "at the present time" with "now."
 2. **Omit trite, unnecessary expressions** — Replace "Please be advised that we have received your application" with "We have received your application."
 3. **Replace wordy conventional statements** — Replace "Please find attached the document you requested" with "The requested document is attached."
 4. **Avoid overusing empty phrases** — Replace "There are several issues that should be addressed" with "Several issues should be addressed."
 5. **Omit "which" and "that" clauses** — Replace "The laptop that I purchased yesterday is defective" with "The laptop I purchased yesterday is defective."
 6. **Eliminate unnecessary prepositional phrases** — Replace "The manager of the department of sales" with "The sales department manager."
 7. **Limit use of the passive voice** — Replace "The report will be reviewed by the committee" with "The committee will review the report."
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PQ7. What are the four benefits of Completeness in business messages? Why can an incomplete message be legally dangerous?

Answer:

The four benefits of complete messages:

1. They are **more likely to bring desired results** without additional messages
2. They **build goodwill** by showing concern for the receiver's needs
3. They can **help avert costly lawsuits** that may result when important information is missing
4. **Even seemingly inconsequential communications can be surprisingly important** when complete

Legal danger of incomplete messages: If important information is missing from a contract, warranty, agreement, safety instruction, or policy message, the sending organization may be held legally liable for damages caused by that missing information. For example, if safety instructions for a product are incomplete and a user is injured, the manufacturer can face lawsuits based on what was *not* included in the communication. The book specifically states: *"Complete messages help avert costly lawsuits that may result if important information is missing."*